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# Timor-Leste | Digital Presence & Positioning Assessment

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# Executive Summary

This report assesses whether Timor-Leste's digital presence is structurally capable of supporting the demand signals identified in the previous report.While global search behavior and sentiment analysis indicate credible interest—particularly in marine and eco-nature experiences—this assessment finds that the current digital ecosystem does not yet fully support progression from awareness to confident trip planning.

Across four areas of evaluation—official web presence, storytelling and content architecture, comparative positioning, and international tour operator representation—several consistent patterns emerge.

**1. Official Tourism Website Audit**

The official tourism website performs adequately as an introductory awareness platform but is significantly weaker as a planning tool.

Strengths include visual appeal, broad thematic coverage, and the communication of Timor-Leste's distinctive assets—particularly marine environments, landscapes, and cultural authenticity. The site signals uniqueness and aligns broadly with the types of experiences travelers search for. However, structural weaknesses limit its effectiveness beyond the inspiration stage. Navigation pathways do not consistently guide users toward itinerary construction or trip logic.

Practical travel information—transport sequencing, realistic trip combinations, indicative durations, or cost framing—is fragmented or underdeveloped. Search engine optimization depth is limited, with insufficient structured content targeting research-stage queries. Calls to action are diffuse, and conversion pathways are not clearly defined.

In short, the website introduces Timor-Leste effectively but does not sufficiently operationalize a visit.

**Digital Storytelling & Content Gaps**

Digital storytelling across official channels emphasizes authenticity, remoteness, biodiversity, and cultural depth. These narratives are consistent with how the destination is described in international media and review platforms. The tone is aligned with exploratory and experience-driven travelers.

The gap lies in sequencing and specificity. Much of the content explains what makes Timor-Leste unique, but less frequently demonstrates how a trip unfolds in practice. There is limited use of model itineraries, scenario-based trip examples, or structured thematic pathways (e.g., 5-day dive trip, 7-day nature loop, Dili + Atauro combination). Imagery is evocative but not always paired with logistical clarity.

As a result, storytelling remains aspirational rather than transitional. It supports dreaming, but not always researching.

**Comparative Benchmark of Reference Tourism Websites**

When benchmarked against selected regional reference destinations—Indonesia, Papua New Guinea, and the Solomon Islands—the most notable difference is not scale, but structural depth.

Comparator destinations more consistently provide:

- Clear itinerary templates and regional circuits
- Thematic landing pages targeting specific interests
- Structured marine and diving information
- Stronger SEO alignment with search-stage queries

These destinations more explicitly guide visitors from interest to decision by presenting how experiences combine geographically and temporally.

Timor-Leste's distinctiveness is not weaker than its comparators. In fact, its marine positioning is competitive. The divergence lies in digital scaffolding: competitor sites reduce uncertainty earlier in the journey.

**Tour Operator Representation & Product Listing Quality**

International tour operator representation is present but uneven. Timor-Leste appears within adventure, diving, and niche eco-tour portfolios, but product listings often lack depth, standardized structure, or consistent quality presentation.

In many cases:

- Itineraries are minimally detailed
- Logistical sequencing is unclear
- Differentiation between comfort tiers is weak
- Pricing transparency is limited

Where listings are well-developed—particularly in diving contexts—the destination is positioned clearly and credibly. However, inconsistency across operators reduces perceived reliability and planning confidence.

This fragmentation reinforces the middle-of-funnel gap identified in the previous report: awareness exists, but structured booking pathways are under-supported.

Timor-Leste's digital presence communicates uniqueness and authenticity effectively. It does not suffer from negative perception, weak storytelling, or absence of distinctive assets.

The primary constraint is structural coherence.

The ecosystem does not yet consistently:

- Translate search interest into structured trip logic
- Provide sufficient research-stage clarity
- Stabilize presentation across official and third-party channels
- Reduce perceived complexity early enough in the journey

Marine and diving assets represent the clearest digital strength and the most viable strategic anchor. Broader expansion into new segments or aggressive awareness campaigns without strengthening planning infrastructure risks increasing curiosity without increasing conversion.

Deliverable 2 therefore concludes that the priority is not increased promotion, but increased digital readiness. Output 3 will translate these findings into strategic sequencing—identifying which product clusters to consolidate, which digital gaps to address first, and where institutional and capacity-building efforts must focus to unlock sustainable demand growth

# 1. Framing the Digital Presence and Positioning Assessment

## 1.1 Purpose and Scope of the Digital Presence Assessment

The previous report established how Timor-Leste is currently discovered, searched, perceived, and discussed across digital channels. It identified global search patterns, traveler segments, sentiment signals, and competitive positioning within the regional landscape. In doing so, it clarified where attention exists and how the destination is interpreted once encountered.

This report builds directly on that foundation. Its purpose is not to reassess perception or demand signals, but to evaluate whether Timor-Leste's digital presence is structurally capable of supporting the behaviors. If travelers are searching for diving, eco-adventure, or cultural immersion, does the digital ecosystem respond with clarity?

If sentiment analysis highlights strengths in marine experiences but friction in service consistency, are those themes reflected, addressed, or reinforced online?

This assessment therefore focuses on digital readiness rather than demand creation. It examines whether official channels, third-party representations, and narrative positioning enable progression from interest to confident planning. It does not evaluate physical infrastructure, macro-level tourism policy, or brand redesign. Instead, it assesses digital usability, content coherence, SEO visibility, storytelling effectiveness, and representation across international tour operators.

In essence, the first report asked: *How is Timor-Leste seen?*
We now ask: *Is the destination digitally prepared for how it is being seen?*

## 1.2 Assessment Framework: Journey, Segments, and Evidence

This assessment continues with the same conceptual structure of the Digital Travel Journey. This framework follows how travel demand forms and progresses in digital environments: Awareness (Dreaming) → Researching (Evaluation & Planning) → Booking → Experience → Sharing (Post-Visit Advocacy)

This is used to evaluate whether Timor-Leste's digital presence supports progression between stages—particularly the transition flagged as most fragile: movement from awareness into researching and planning. The assessment therefore tests whether official content (through timorleste.tl, the official tourism website) and third-party representations (through international tour operator listings) provide the practical clarity, reassurance, and structure that travelers seek once initial interest is established.

Comparator destinations—Indonesia, Papua New Guinea, and the Solomon Islands—are used as reference points for how destinations in the region translate niche assets into digital clarity and planning confidence, primarily through their own tourism websites.

Using the same journey framework, the same segments, and the same regional reference points ensures this assessment functions as the "digital readiness" counterpart to the previous report's "digital demand" diagnostic. This continuity sets up the final report, where strategic prioritization will translate these findings into a sequenced roadmap of actions, capacity-building needs, and implementation mechanisms

# 2. Official Tourism Website Audit

For the tourism website audit component, you can indicate that this section is based on publicly available data and that certain elements remain preliminary pending additional information. Once the data is available, you can integrate it and update the work.

While international media, influencers, and search engines often create the first moment of awareness, the official site is where travelers look for confirmation, reassurance, and practical clarity.

This section assesses whether the website is technically fit for that role. Rather than evaluating the site purely against abstract technical standards, the focus here is on whether it reliably supports discovery, exploration, and planning—particularly for international users and mobile visitors. It assesses whether the website enables travelers to move from inspiration to planning and validation, in line with the demand signals, traveler segments, and intent gaps previously identified.

**Methodological Approach**

The website audit is structured around four diagnostic lenses: usability and information architecture, content depth and relevance, SEO performance and discoverability, and branding consistency and

governance signals. Each lens corresponds to a critical function the website must perform within the traveler decision journey.

Assessment is based on:

- manual review of key pages and navigation paths
- use of free or widely accessible diagnostic tools
- comparison against traveler needs and intent patterns identified earlier in the assessment

Findings are synthesized into audit matrices and priority friction points, rather than exhaustive page-by-page commentary. Detailed tools, scoring logic, and procedural guidance are documented separately in **Annex B** for transparency and future replication.

## 2.1 Overall Technical Health

From a structural perspective, the official tourism website is well maintained.

A full crawl of the site found no evidence of widespread technical degradation. Pages load consistently, internal navigation functions as expected, and there are no signs of neglected or broken site sections. This level of baseline reliability is notable for a public-sector destination website and provides a solid foundation for future content and marketing efforts.

Across **268 pages reviewed**, only **eight broken or unreachable links** were identified. This represents a very low error rate and indicates good editorial discipline and ongoing upkeep. Importantly, none of the issues identified affect core navigation, trip planning content, or user journeys.

Most broken links fall into predictable and low-risk categories:

- external organizations that have changed or removed pages over time
- minor domain or URL inconsistencies
- non-essential links to third-party commercial sites
- automated email-protection links flagged by scanners rather than by real users

Taken together, these findings indicate that link integrity is not a material issue for the site, and that technical maintenance is already operating at an acceptable standard.

## 2.2 Performance and User Experience (Desktop vs Mobile)

Performance testing indicates a divergence between desktop and mobile user experience on the official tourism website.

On desktop devices, the site performs strongly. Pages load quickly, primary content appears promptly, and interactions such as scrolling and navigation respond smoothly. These results suggest that the site's underlying infrastructure, hosting environment, and general build quality are sound.

On mobile devices, however, performance is more constrained. Key visual elements—particularly large images and hero content at the top of pages—take longer to appear. In addition, some layout elements adjust position as the page loads, which can create a sense of instability during the first moments of use.

From a technical standpoint, this pattern is consistent with:

- heavy above-the-fold images that are not fully optimized for mobile delivery
- render-blocking resources (such as stylesheets or scripts) that delay initial visual display
- insufficient prioritization of the most important page elements for mobile connections

Measured indicators reinforce this observation. Mobile tests show slower First Contentful Paint (FCP) and Largest Contentful Paint (LCP) times than recommended benchmarks, while desktop results remain comfortably within expected ranges.

These issues do not prevent users from accessing content, nor do they indicate system failure. However, they do affect perceived speed, which is often more influential than absolute load time. For first-time visitors—particularly those arriving via search, media links, or social sharing—slower mobile loading can subtly reduce confidence and willingness to explore further.

## 2.3 Core Web Vitals and Technical Quality Signals

Core Web Vitals provide a standardized way to assess how users experience a website in practice, particularly on mobile devices. These metrics focus on three aspects of experience: how quickly main content becomes visible, how stable the page layout is during loading, and how responsive the site feels to user interaction.

For the Timor-Leste tourism website, these signals present a mixed but understandable profile.

Interaction-related metrics perform well. Once the page has loaded, scrolling, tapping, and navigating between elements feel responsive. This indicates that the site does not suffer from excessive processing delays or heavy interaction-blocking scripts.

The main weaknesses appear earlier in the loading sequence:

- Largest Contentful Paint (LCP) on mobile is slower than recommended, meaning the most important visual element on the page appears later than ideal.
- Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS) is elevated on some pages, reflecting small but noticeable layout movements as content loads.

These signals are particularly relevant for tourism websites because visual content carries much of the storytelling and reassurance burden. When key imagery loads slowly or shifts unexpectedly, it can weaken the emotional impact of the page, even if the underlying content quality is strong.

It is important to emphasize that these issues are localized and technical in nature, not structural. They typically stem from:

- image sizing and compression choices
- the order in which page resources are loaded
- lack of reserved space for images or dynamic elements

As such, they are addressable through targeted optimisation, rather than requiring redesign or platform change.

**What the sitemap reveals (and why it matters)**

The website's sitemap provides a snapshot of how the site is being presented to search engines. Overall, the site has a clear page structure (destinations, what-to-do, plan-your-trip, listings, and documents), which is a strong foundation for search visibility.

However, it also suggests that the sitemap may not be actively maintained as a living technical asset: many pages show a "last modified" date in early 2020, and the sitemap appears to have been generated using a third-party tool rather than directly from the site's content management system.

In practical terms, this does not prevent the site from being indexed, but it can reduce confidence signals for freshness and create avoidable "noise" for search engines. The sitemap includes duplicate URL variations (for example with and without trailing slashes) and a number of filter-based URLs (parameter pages), which can dilute crawl attention away from the most important pages for travelers.

**Implication for the website audit**

This is a solvable governance issue rather than a structural flaw. A refreshed, CMS-generated sitemap (paired with basic rules about which pages should and should not be indexed) would strengthen technical SEO hygiene and improve the efficiency with which search engines discover and prioritize the site's highest-value content.

## 2.4 Search Visibility & Technical SEO

*Search Console insights to be incorporated*

This section will be expanded using data from Google Search Console, which provides visibility into how the site performs for real users rather than simulated tests.

Once available, Search Console data will be used to:

- confirm how widespread mobile performance issues are across the site
- identify which pages are most affected
- review indexation coverage and crawl health
- assess any mobile usability warnings or technical constraints

This will allow technical recommendations to be prioritised based on impact rather than assumption, and will strengthen the evidence base for future optimisation work.

### 2.5 What This Means for Timor-Leste's Digital Readiness

From a strategic perspective, the findings point to a clear and encouraging conclusion:

- The official tourism website is technically stable and trustworthy
- There is no evidence of systemic technical failure or neglect
- The site is suitable as a central, authoritative destination platform
- The main constraint is mobile performance optimisation, not site architecture or governance

This matters because it means future improvements can focus on making the site feel faster, clearer, and more confident, rather than rebuilding fundamentals. Addressing mobile performance will strengthen first impressions, support deeper exploration, and reinforce trust at the point where curiosity begins to turn into planning.

Detailed diagnostics, performance metrics, and technical recommendations will be documented separately in a **Technical Annex**, allowing this main report to remain accessible and decision-focused while preserving full transparency and evidence for technical stakeholders.

## 3. Digital Storytelling & Content Gaps

**"What stories are told — and what is missing?"**

This review consolidates a first-pass content and storytelling audit of the official tourism website (timorleste.tl), focusing on how well the site supports a traveler's journey from inspiration to planning, and how consistently the content reinforces trust.

The findings are grounded in observed page content across core sections including destination pages, "What to do," planning guidance, directories (businesses and accommodation), events, and legal/policy pages.

In addition to identifying "what exists," this pass highlights where the current content structure creates friction: missing "next step" guidance, broken or inconsistent templates, and pathways that do not

reliably connect inspiration pages (activities / destinations) to planning tools (itineraries / listings / transport / accommodation). These are solvable issues that primarily require content governance and template harmonization rather than wholesale rebuilding.

**What the website already does well**

The site's overall information architecture is aligned to how travelers think: it offers clear high-level entry points for destinations, activities, and trip planning, supported by a directory model that can scale as the tourism ecosystem grows.

Several "Plan your trip" pages demonstrate strong visitor value by providing concrete and safety-relevant guidance, including practical safety considerations (e.g., crocodiles, driving conditions, water safety, mosquitoes, currents) and general travel tips such as seasonality for activities and cultural etiquette.

The directory approach is a real asset. The business directory and accommodation directory are structured with filters (e.g., by municipality and listing type), which is the right foundation for helping users move from "reading about possibilities" to "finding specific operators or places."
The "What to do" area also does a valuable piece of expectation management by stating that travelers may need to contact operators directly (email/phone/WhatsApp), reflecting the realities of a developing destination and reducing frustration for users who expect instant booking.

**Where the storytelling and traveler journey break down**

A clear pattern across multiple pages is that "inspiration" content often stops just short of telling travelers what to do next—where to go, when to go, how long to allow, and who to contact.

For example, the fishing page successfully sets the scene (species and experience), but the next-step pathway is vague ("arrange to go out with Timorese fishers…") without clear location cues, practical options, or links to relevant operators.

Similarly, high-potential conservation and nature pages explain significance but remain light on visitability. The national park page describes scope, biodiversity, and the fact that facilities and protections are still being established, but does not translate that into "how to visit responsibly," recommended access points, guiding expectations, or what an itinerary could look like.

The protected areas page notes "fifteen terrestrial areas" and marine protected areas, but does not provide user-friendly mapping, traveler implications, or link-outs to "how to experience this" content.

Where the site is strongest is when it bridges directly into "doable planning." The hiking/walking page is a good example: it names specific experiences, gives rough time/effort context, and clarifies the role of

guides.  The snorkeling and diving pages also show stronger conversion potential by embedding a directory-style “find a dive centre.”

The opportunity is to extend that same pattern consistently across other activity pages (markets, festivals, fishing, beaches, heritage).

A second storytelling gap is cross-linking and “journey stitching.” The site contains three major content systems that should reinforce each other but currently behave like separate islands:

- Activities (“What to do”) content that inspires and educates.
- Destinations content (popular locations and municipalities) that can anchor geographic planning.
- Itineraries content that translates interest into a route and a timed plan.

The content gap is not “lack of material,” but rather the absence of obvious pathways such as: “This experience appears in these itineraries,” “This municipality is best explored via these routes,” and “These operators support this activity.” This is especially important for an “off the beaten path” destination positioning, where reassurance and clarity are part of the brand promise.

**Content quality and governance risks that undermine trust**

The itinerary system is a high-value asset, but it currently contains clear inconsistencies between the itinerary index and the detail pages. For example, the itinerary index lists “Atauro Island Visit” as “Central Zone – 4 Days,” while the detail page itself shows “2 Days.”  The index lists “Explore Dili to Jaco” as “2 Days,” but the detail page presents it as “4 Days.”  “Explore Dili to Com” is shown as “4 Days” on the index but “3 Days +” on the detail page.

Because itineraries are “decision-making” content, these mismatches can quickly erode confidence, even when the underlying writing is fine.

Template hygiene issues are also visible across key directory content, especially accommodation and listings pages. Multiple accommodation and listing pages show unrendered shortcodes (for example [/su_section]) and raw serialized location data where users would expect a clean map/address block. Even when the core content is useful, this kind of formatting exposure reads as “broken” to users and reduces the perceived professionalism of the official platform.

There is also evidence of content integrity problems that should be treated as urgent. The Terms & Conditions page includes what appears to be an unrelated external backlink embedded in the page body (“Primos Bo’ot Accountants Timor-Leste”), which is atypical for a legal page on an official site.

The travel tips page similarly contains an out-of-place phrase (“Accounting and business consulting Timor-Leste.”) inserted into the financial guidance area. In official websites, unexpected backlinks in legal or advisory pages are often associated with attempted SEO spam injection and warrant a security/content integrity review.

A final governance signal is the presence of “draft-like” or stray editorial text in destination content (for instance, “Make some changes” appearing mid-paragraph on a municipality page), which again suggests inconsistent publishing QA.

**Priority content fixes and storytelling upgrades for a first pass**

This priority list is designed for a “first pass” that improves user experience quickly, while also creating a durable structure for ongoing storytelling.

The highest-impact quick win is to make the itineraries internally consistent and then promote them as the site’s main “planning product.” This means aligning duration labels between the itinerary hub page and each itinerary detail page, and confirming that zone labels, stay locations, and day numbering match. The itinerary pages are already structured with day-by-day segments and route maps; once accurate, they can become the connective tissue that links municipalities, popular locations, and activities into “doable trips.”

The second quick win is removing or correcting clear trust-eroding anomalies in “official” pages: the Terms & Conditions page backlink insertion and the travel tips page’s unrelated phrase should be reviewed, removed if inappropriate, and protected against recurrence through publishing controls.

A third quick win is stabilizing directory templates (accommodation and listings) so that every profile page presents cleanly: no shortcode artifacts, no raw metadata dumps, and consistent placement of contact details, location, and booking/action buttons where available. This is both a quality issue and a partner-support issue, because these pages function as a semi-official “digital storefront” for local operators and accommodations.

The next tier of upgrades strengthens storytelling without requiring a large content production burden. Many activity pages would benefit from a consistent “How to experience this” module, using scannable headings and structured subsections (e.g., best season, where to go, typical duration, safety notes, how to book, related itineraries, relevant operators). Structuring long pages with headings is also an accessibility and navigation best practice, benefiting all users and assistive technologies.

Finally, there is an opportunity to strengthen “signature themes” where the site already has compelling raw material. Birding content notes a strong biodiversity proposition (240+ species and endemic species). Marine wildlife content positions the destination as a whale and dolphin hotspot and identifies a migration season. Given increasing global scrutiny of wildlife tourism impacts, this is also a space to reinforce responsible viewing guidance and avoid encouraging high-risk interactions; recent reporting highlights concerns that poorly governed whale tourism can disrupt whale behavior and harm the resource it depends on.

## 3.1 Narrative Themes and Imagery Assessment

**What version of Timor-Leste is being presented digitally, and how consistently is it communicated?**

Across the website, Timor-Leste is presented as:

- Off the beaten path
- Rich in nature and marine life
- Culturally distinct and community-oriented
- A destination for curious, independent travelers

These themes are coherent and positive. The site avoids over-commercialisation and positions Timor-Leste as a place of authenticity rather than mass tourism. This aligns well with the country's current stage of tourism development and with international interest in lesser-known destinations.

However, the narrative is largely descriptive rather than experiential. Pages explain *what exists*, but less often show *what it feels like* to travel through Timor-Leste or how experiences connect over time.

Imagery is generally strong, particularly:

- underwater and marine photography
- landscapes and coastal environments
- selected destination and municipality pages

Where imagery is present, it successfully conveys a sense of remoteness and natural beauty.

That said, imagery is unevenly deployed:

- several templates (listings, accommodation, municipalities) have missing or broken header images
- some activity pages rely on maps rather than visual storytelling
- human presence (travelers, guides, communities) is less visible than landscapes

As a result, imagery supports **place awareness** more than **experience imagination**.

The overall balance leans heavily toward **informational content**:

- factual descriptions
- lists of places and services
- institutional language in some sections (notably news and partner pages)

Moments of emotional storytelling do exist—particularly in culture, history, and nature pages—but they are not consistently activated or connected to trip planning.

The site communicates credibility and substance, but underuses emotion as a tool to move visitors from interest to intent.

## 3.2 Content Gap Analysis by Journey Stage

This section evaluates how well the official tourism website supports travelers across the five stages of the digital journey: Awareness, Researching, Booking, Experience, and Sharing. The goal is not to assess volume of content, but whether content supports progression from curiosity to commitment.

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The goal is not to assess volume of content, but whether content supports progression from curiosity to commitment.

### 1. Awareness (Dreaming)

Gap: Inspiration Is Present but Unguided

The site contains strong nature, marine, and cultural storytelling, but inspiration is dispersed across multiple standalone pages. High-interest topics such as whales, birds, hiking, and culture are described, yet they are rarely connected into seasonal narratives or sample journeys.

Visitors must assemble meaning themselves rather than being guided through a coherent story (e.g., “October is ideal for whales and reef diving” or “Combine mountains and markets in one week”).

### 2. Researching (Evaluation & Planning)

Gap: Planning Scaffolding Is Inconsistent

Itineraries exist, which is a major strength, but they are inconsistently labeled and not strongly connected to activity or destination pages. Activity pages often describe what can be done, but do not consistently answer practical planning questions such as duration, sequencing, where to base oneself, or when conditions are optimal.

For example:

- Hiking pages describe routes but lack standardized difficulty, time estimates, and gear guidance.
- Cultural pages explain meaning but rarely frame experiences in half-day or full-day formats.
- Marine content highlights biodiversity but does not consistently present technical dive details or logistics.

### 3. Booking

Gap: Conversion Pathways Are Fragmented

Directories and operator listings exist, but template inconsistencies and layout artifacts reduce perceived clarity. Activities and destinations do not always link clearly to operators or bookable services.

There is limited visibility of:

- Structured product packaging
- Clear calls to action (“Contact this operator for X experience”)
- Consolidated booking pathways

This is especially important for marine and adventure travelers who demonstrate higher research sophistication

### 4. Experience (On-Ground Support)

Gap: Expectation Setting Is Uneven

The tone is honest about infrastructure limitations, which builds credibility. However, expectation-setting is not consistently structured.

For example:

- Whale watching mentions responsible practice but does not clearly outline visitor-facing behavioral guidelines.
- Transport guidance is realistic but not summarized in one consolidated planning hub.
- Connectivity (WiFi) — a recurring review theme— is not proactively contextualized.

### 5. Sharing (Post-Visit Advocacy)

**“How does this experience feed future demand?”**

Gap: Limited Amplification of Visitor Stories

There are few visible recent visitor-facing stories, blogs, or curated testimonials. News content tends to focus on industry developments rather than visitor experience. Given that review sentiment — particularly for diving and hospitality — is strong, the site does not actively amplify this validation.

**Cross-Stage Structural Diagnosis**

Across the five stages, a consistent pattern emerges:

| Stage | Structural Weakness |
|---|---|

| | |
|---|---|
| Awareness | Inspiration is thematic but not sequenced |
| Researching | Activities lack standardized planning scaffolding |
| Booking | Conversion signals and operator integration are inconsistent |
| Experience | Expectation-setting uneven |
| Sharing | Advocacy under-leveraged |

The strongest stages are Awareness and Experience. The weakest stage is Researching, where progression into structured planning slows. The site tells compelling stories about Timor-Leste. However, across multiple stages, the content architecture does not consistently translate inspiration into structured, decision-ready pathways. The opportunity is not more content. It is stronger progression logic across the five-stage journey.

## 3.3 Content Gaps by Traveler Segment

| **Traveler Segment** | **Where Content Is Strong** | **Structural / Content Gaps** | **Strategic Risk Level** |
|---|---|---|---|
| Adventure, Eco-Exploration & Nature | - Detailed hiking examples (Mt Ramelau, Matebian, Mundo Perdido)<br>- Realistic transport notes (4WD requirements, road conditions)<br>- Encouragement of local guides<br>- Nature positioning aligns with remote/adventure narrative | - No consistent difficulty grading system<br>- Limited structured duration guidance<br>- Gear expectations not standardized<br>- External links (e.g., trekking sites) substitute for internal planning scaffolding<br>- No unified “How to plan this activity” format | **Moderate–High**<br>Impacts research planning progression |
| Marine, Diving, Sailing & Yachting | - Coral Triangle positioning clearly articulated<br>- Whale/dolphin season window identified (Oct–Dec)<br>- Marine protected areas framed<br>- Dive operator listings present<br>- Marine sentiment strongest across review platforms | - No dedicated sailing or yachting pages<br>- Limited technical dive detail (depths, currents, skill levels)<br>- Responsible whale watching mentioned but not operationalized with clear visitor rules<br>- Sailing/yachting infrastructure details limited<br>- Listing template artifacts weaken high-intent conversion | **High**<br>Affects highest-yield segment |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| Cultural, Experiential & Couple-Oriented | - Strong history and resistance narrative<br>- Heritage recognition content<br>- Markets, museums, artisan cooperatives listed<br>- Editorial credibility aligns with international framing | - Cultural activities not structured as time-bound experiences<br>- No thematic cultural itineraries<br>- Limited event/festival pathway integration<br>- Long narrative pages lack scannable structure for planning | **Moderate**<br>Limits planning confidence |
| Backpackers & Budget Independent | - Accommodation listings available<br>- Positive solo-traveler review signals<br>- Functional OTA presence | - No structured independent route guidance<br>- Budget filters not clearly surfaced<br>- Template inconsistencies affect clarity<br>- Official site has limited influence on peer-driven segment | **Low–Moderate**<br>Lower strategic yield |

Across all four segments, the primary weakness is structural rather than thematic. The site tells strong stories — about reefs, mountains, culture, and authenticity — but does not consistently organize experiences into time-bound, decision-ready formats. Duration-based guidance ("If you have 7 days, here's a logical route") is largely absent, even though search signals show limited itinerary-depth progression. Additionally, template inconsistencies in listings and directories reduce clarity at the exact moment when high-intent travelers are seeking reassurance.

## 3.4 Narrative themes and imagery assessment

Across the strongest pages, the site presents a consistent "destination identity" built around three dominant narrative themes:

Off-the-beaten-path exploration and discovery. The site repeatedly positions the experience as "hidden gems," "road less travelled," and rewarding exploration, especially through the "Exploring" page and culture/heritage framing.

Marine and nature richness (especially marine wildlife). Marine biodiversity, diving, and wildlife viewing are elevated as signature strengths, with explicit emphasis on the Coral Triangle context, high reef diversity, and seasonal whale/dolphin viewing in the straits near and cultural identity and lived heritage. The site frames culture through history, storytelling, and everyday life (markets, hospitality, museums), with strong potential to translate into traveler-facing cultural experiences.

Together, these themes define a credible "promise": remote, authentic, nature-rich, culturally distinct. Where the narrative weakens is not the identity itself, but how consistently it is activated into "doable planning" content.

**Use of imagery and emotional vs informational balance**

The site uses imagery heavily in principle (many pages are image-led, and posts often include photo credits), and there is clear intent to develop a destination photo library through initiatives such as a tourism photo competition.

However, there are two content-management patterns that reduce the effectiveness of imagery as a storytelling tool:

- Imagery is sometimes undermined by template/rendering issues on high-volume pages. Multiple accommodation and listings pages display shortcode artifacts (e.g., "[/su_section]") and/or raw location data where visitors would expect a clean hero image and structured at-a-glance information.
- Some content is strong emotionally (descriptive and evocative), but not consistently "scannable" for quick decision-making. Long-form pages such as marine wildlife viewing provide rich narrative but can be difficult to scan for "when, where, how, and with whom" without clear internal headings and "quick answers."

This matters for accessibility and usability: W3C guidance emphasizes headings and structure as a core way users navigate long pages, including people using assistive technologies and those who need fast orientation.

A useful reference point for future traveler acquisition is also Google's Discover guidance, which explicitly highlights the value of compelling, high-quality images (and clear titles) in driving content visibility and engagement.

**Content gap analysis by journey stage**

The site performs well at "dreaming moments" by presenting a high diversity of activities and landscape types—marine, hiking, culture, markets—and by framing the experience as discovery-driven.

Some inspiration pages are already close to "conversion-ready" because they connect to operators or structured listings. The arts & crafts page, for example, blends narrative introduction with a "find places" module that lists specific venues and locations.

Inspiration pages often answer "why it's special," but not consistently "how to experience it." This is clearest where content is evocative but the next-step pathway is generic. For example, the fishing page describes the experience and species, but the action guidance remains broad (arrange with fishers / charter a boat) without helping users evaluate where to do this, what a typical trip looks like, and how to arrange it.

There are also places where topic overlap and page composition create confusion. The beaches page contains substantial marine/diving narrative and operator references, but it does not clearly support a

traveler who specifically wants to compare beaches (where to go near  vs near the capital, accessibility, facilities, safety notes).

### Planning-stage support

The planning hub (“Plan your trip”) points users toward itineraries and transport guidance and attempts to function as a trip-planning entry point.
Core planning pages provide concrete, helpful detail—for example:

- Safety and health guidance (crocodiles, driving conditions, water safety, mosquito-borne disease risk, ocean currents).
- Practical travel tips (seasons for diving/trekking/fishing; telecoms and power realities; currency and card limitations).
- Transport guidance including the practical need for 4WD in specific access routes, and references to domestic flights.
- Arriving guidance including the requirement for an electronic entry form and visa details, anchored to an official immigration domain.

The accommodation finder and business directory both use filter-based search interfaces that are structurally well-suited to helping users move from “reading” to “selecting.”

The site also clearly sets expectations that travelers may need to contact providers directly, which is honest and appropriate for many developing destination markets.

Where the journey breaks The key planning asset—recommended itineraries—is currently undermined by internal consistency issues. The itinerary index lists “Atauro Island Visit” as “Central Zone – 4 Days,” while the detail page shows “2 Days,” which creates immediate confusion for travelers comparing options.

Because itineraries function as “decision products,” mismatches like this have a disproportionate impact on confidence and can cause users to abandon planning on the official site.

A second planning-stage break is “template reliability” in directories. Users may successfully find accommodation via filters, but then land on detailed templates that show shortcode artifacts and raw metadata. The Atauro Dive Resort accommodation page, for example, contains “[/su_section]” and serialized data in the location field.

This is not only a technical quality issue; it also disrupts the planning journey at the exact moment users are making decisions.

A third planning-stage opportunity is to reduce “information scatter” by connecting systems. The exploring page describes popular trips and states that operators offer itineraries, but this concept is not

consistently reinforced through “this activity appears in these itineraries” linkages across activities, destinations, and directories.

## 3.5 Priority recommendations from the journey mapping

The most actionable outputs from Pass 2 are “journey stitching” interventions: fixes and content modules that connect what already exists, reduce confusion, and move users forward.

**Fix the planning spine first**
The itinerary hub is already a strong concept, but it cannot function as the core planning product until durations and labels are consistent between index and detail pages.

Once corrected, itineraries can become the default “next step” CTA across activity pages, municipality pages, and planning pages, aligning directly with “time-to-make-a-plan” intent moments.

**Standardize “How to experience this” modules**

For top segment pages (diving, dolphins/whales, hiking, markets, heritage/culture), a consistent scannable module should answer:

- best time to go
- where to do it
- typical duration and difficulty
- safety/etiquette notes
- how to book/contact
- related itineraries and operators

This improves usability and accessibility because it creates predictable structure and headings.

**Repair trust leaks in official pages**

Remove or correct stray, irrelevant text appearing in traveler-facing pages (travel tips, terms & conditions), and treat this as a governance priority because it affects institutional credibility.
In the main report, this can be framed as “content integrity and editorial QA improvements,” while the technical annex can document the exact page instances and remediation steps.

**Turn directories into conversion tools**

The accommodation and business directory interfaces are structurally valuable, but they must land users on clean, stable templates. Page artifacts like “[/su_section]” and raw serialized location data should be treated as high-priority fixes because they disrupt the journey at the point of decision.

**Make events navigable and shareable**

As currently presented, the events calendar reads like an information table rather than a travel-planning tool. Converting event entries into clickable pages (even lightweight detail pages) improves traveler utility, supports Discover/shareability, and reduces reliance on raw URLs in tables.

# 4. Comparative Benchmark of Reference Tourism Websites for Timor-Leste

This benchmark reviews three reference tourism websites:

- Solomon Islands - visitsolomons.com.sb
- Papua New Guinea - papuanewguinea.travel
- Indonesia - indonesia.travel

The same practical lens applied to timorleste.tl is used to see how effectively a site (a) communicates a destination narrative and visual identity, (b) supports the traveler journey (inspiration → planning → validation), and (c) serves priority segments (eco & marine, adventure, cultural).

The review is page-led rather than purely impressionistic. Representative sections were examined across each site: “things to do/experiences,” trip-planning guidance (getting around, practical tips), event information, destination/region hubs, and where present, itineraries/tours and editorial/storytelling.

## 4.1 Overview of Competitor Tourism Websites

Across all three reference competitors, the strongest differentiator is not “how much content,” but how content is packaged into planning pathways:

- Structured events
- Itinerary/tour formats
- Filters/search tools
- Internal linking that helps travelers move forward without guesswork

**Tourism Solomons: a narrative-led site with built-in “provider search”**

In tone and storytelling, the Solomon Islands site leans into a clear emotional promise—remoteness, “fall off the map,” living culture, and ocean-based experiences—while keeping copy concise and oriented around experience categories (e.g., trekking, scuba diving). Nearly everything on the front page is oriented around the action of planning a trip:

- A navigation bar with items Where To Stay, Things To Do, Plan Your Adventure, Where To Book, About Solomon and Book Now
- A second set of buttons just under the main photo with Things To Do, Plan Your Trip, Destinations, and About Solomon Islands

Another feature is the repeated presence of a site-wide “search machine” (filters by keyword/category/destination/things-to-do/province) and “Providers” sections on experience pages.

This converts inspiration content into a practical discovery tool without requiring a full booking platform. On events, the Solomon Islands approach is “planning oriented” (encouraging travelers to plan trips around festivals, with a downloadable annual calendar reference).

Editorially, the site includes traveler-facing feature content (including an itinerary-style article published in 2025), which supports inspiration and reassurance (“someone has done this and here’s how”).

**papuanewguinea.travel (PNGTPA): a planning-forward site with structured events and itinerary/tour products**

Papua New Guinea’s site is comparatively journey engineered. It explicitly invites trip planning through interactive and navigational features visible even at the homepage layer (e.g., “Plan your trip,” “Take the travel quiz,” and “Discover your next adventure”). Though the travel quiz is not currently functioning correctly, the groundwork is laid for an interactive, useful tool for planning trips.

A standout is the events system: events appear as individual pages with structured fields (location, region), practical contacts (phone/email), and detailed programs and highlights. This is materially more usable than a static calendar table because it supports scanning, sharing, and decision-making. The site also currently supports 15 languages.

The site also includes itinerary/tour product pages that show pricing, accommodation nights, and an itinerary breakdown with calls to action (“Enquire,” “Visit Website”). This bridges directly from inspiration to conversion while still routing commercial fulfillment to operators.

Destination/region pages demonstrate a strong planning template style: clear positioning, plus structured “where it is and how to get there” guidance and transport gateway logic. This reduces traveler uncertainty and supports itinerary building.

**indonesia.travel (Wonderful Indonesia): extreme depth and multilingual reach, with template-driven destination guides**

Indonesia’s platform is defined by scale: destination hubs within major regions list multiple cities/areas and surface “travel blog” content alongside destination navigation. This creates a continuous loop between discovery (“where to go”) and editorial inspiration (“what to read next”).

Many destination pages use a consistent information architecture: “Get There” logistics, supporting “Nearby” recommendations, and experience framing that mixes emotional language with practical guidance (transport options, distance/time references).
Indonesia’s strongest comparative advantage is multilingual capability: evidence of language-localized routes includes Indonesian (id/id), English (id/en, gb/en), French (fr/fr), German (de/de), and Chinese (cn/zh-cn). This supports broader international reach and reduces friction for non-English audiences.

A cautionary note: the overall content depth is high, but quality control appears uneven in places—an important reminder that scale can introduce its own governance challenges.

**Baseline observation for timorleste.tl: strong breadth, weaker "journey stitching"**
Timor-Leste's site already contains a broad inventory: activity pages (including high-interest marine wildlife content) and planning tools like recommended itineraries, plus an events page.

Where it differs from the reference competitors is in the planning handoff: the events experience is static; itineraries exist but require stronger internal consistency, better integration across activities/destinations, and a better introduction to those unfamiliar with the destination; and some accommodation templates show visible formatting artifacts such as shortcode remnants.

Ratings reflect observed evidence across representative pages and systems (events, itineraries/tours, destination hubs, and practical planning content). "Strength" means the feature is present and clearly usable; "Moderate" means present but partial; "Limited" means absent or not consistently usable.

**Table 4.2: Comparative Tourism Website Benchmark**

| Website | Depth of content | Quality and consistency | Range of content | Ease of navigation | Languages |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| timorleste.tl | Moderate (activities + itineraries + accommodation listings). | Moderate (some listing pages show visible template artifacts). | Strong (marine, culture, markets, accommodation). | Moderate (events as table; journey links need strengthening). | Core content presented in English |
| visitsolomons.com.sb | Moderate–Strong (experience pages, planning pages, deals/specials, feature articles). | Strong (clear headings and clean experience-page structure in sampled pages). | Moderate–Strong (adventure + dive + culture + events). | Strong (site-wide "search machine" + "providers" sections facilitate discovery). | Content presented in English in sampled pages |
| papuanewguinea.travel | Strong (destination pages, events library, planning guidance, itineraries/tours). | Strong (consistent event fields + structured destination pages in samples). | Strong (adventure + culture + events + travel logistics). | Strong (events as navigable pages; strong "getting around" content; itinerary product pages). | Possible to translate into 15 languages |

| | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| indonesia.travel | Very strong (large destination library, hubs, and travel blog tie-ins). | Moderate–Strong (rich templates, but evidence of occasional render artifacts in extracted content). | Very strong (nature, culture, adventure, and extensive destination coverage). | Strong (region hubs list cities/areas; destination guides include “Get There” and “Nearby” sections). | Set up for 20 regions and nearly as many languages |

## 4.2 Comparative Tourism Website Interactive Features

This section evaluates how competitor destinations support travelers across key decision moments in the digital travel journey.

While branding and storytelling influence awareness, interactive features and planning tools determine whether interest progresses into structured evaluation and booking intent. The selected feature categories were therefore chosen because they act as conversion infrastructure within the five-stage visitor journey model:

Awareness → Researching → Booking → Experience → Sharing.

Each category below represents a functional bridge between inspiration and commitment.

**1. Events Usability**

**Relevant Journey Stages:** Awareness → Researching

Events content plays a dual role. At the Awareness stage, it adds seasonality and immediacy (“Something is happening there”). At the Researching stage, it helps travelers anchor timing decisions around festivals, cultural activities, or marine seasons.

Destinations with usable event calendars signal vibrancy and current activity. Poorly structured or outdated events pages weaken perceived relevance and freshness.

**2. Itineraries / Tours**

**Relevant Journey Stage:** Researching (Primary), Booking (Secondary)

Itineraries are one of the clearest signals that a destination supports structured trip planning. They help travelers visualize duration, sequencing, and logical routing — directly addressing the gap identified in the previous report, where itinerary-depth searches were limited.

Strong itinerary presentation reduces cognitive load. Weak or buried itineraries slow progression from informational curiosity to commercial intent.

**3. Operator Discovery**

**Relevant Journey Stage:** Booking

At the Booking stage, travelers look for credible service providers. The clarity, usability, and integration of operator listings signal professionalism and readiness.

Effective operator discovery includes:

- Clean listing templates
- Clear calls to action
- Integration with relevant experiences

Inconsistent templates or weak operator integration directly affect conversion confidence.

**4. “Get There / Getting Around” Quality**

**Relevant Journey Stages:** Researching → Booking → Experience

Transport and logistics content directly influences feasibility perception. When transport guidance is clear, realistic, and structured, it reduces anxiety and increases commitment confidence.

This category was selected because, particularly for remote destinations, logistical clarity can determine whether a traveler progresses beyond inspiration. It also sets expectations that affect the Experience stage.

**5. Evidence of Update Cadence**

**Relevant Journey Stages:** Awareness → Sharing

Freshness signals matter. Visible updates (news, recent stories, event postings) demonstrate that tourism is active and current.

A destination that appears static risks:

- Reduced trust
- Lower perceived relevance
- Concern about operational reliability

Update cadence functions as a credibility indicator across multiple stages.

The purpose of this comparison is not to score features mechanically. It is to assess whether competitor destinations:

- Provide clearer progression from Awareness to Researching
- Reduce planning friction at the Researching stage
- Strengthen confidence at Booking
- Reinforce validation signals

These functional differences help explain why some destinations convert digital curiosity into structured demand more effectively.

**Table 4.3: Comparative Tourism Website Practical Planning Features**

| Website | Events usability | Itineraries / tours | Operator discovery | "Get there / getting around" quality | Evidence of update cadence |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| timorleste.tl | Events presented as a calendar table (some links embedded in text), limited interactivity. | Itineraries exist as a hub page with highlights. | Operators referenced in some activity pages (e.g., marine wildlife). | Not assessed here in detail (requires targeted page sampling beyond this competitor set). | Events reference includes 2026 dates. |
| visitsolomons.com.sb | Annual events positioned with downloadable calendar reference. | Traveler-facing itinerary-style editorial exists (e.g., "ultimate 7-day itinerary"), plus deal/specials content. | Built-in "search machine" and "providers" sections on activities. | "Plan your adventure" guidance exists, including packing and getting around. | Feature content includes 2025 publication date. |
| papuanewguinea.travel | High usability: event pages include location/region, contacts, and detailed schedules. | Tour/itinerary pages include price, nights, and day-by-day itinerary with enquiry CTA. | Some pages route to operator sites via enquiry/visit website CTAs. | Strong: dedicated "Getting Around" content with explicit mode guidance. | Events include 2025–2026 references and recent news updates. |
| indonesia.travel | Events exist as a structured concept in "about" navigation; full usability varies by section. | "Trip ideas" and travel blog integration is visible on hubs and pages; not always a priced | Strong cross-linking ("Nearby Spectacles") supports discovery, though operator directories are not | Strong: many destination pages include a "Get There" section. | Multilingual news updates and sections show active campaign communications. |

| | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | itinerary system. | evident in sampled pages. | | |

The comparative feature analysis above highlights structural differences in how destinations support progression across the digital visitor journey. While many destinations share similar thematic content (nature, culture, marine), they differ significantly in how clearly they translate inspiration into structured planning tools.

In particular, competitor sites that surface itineraries prominently, maintain clean operator discovery pathways, and present logistics clearly tend to reduce friction at the **Researching and Booking stages**. By contrast, where planning scaffolding or update signals are weaker, progression often slows between Awareness and structured evaluation.

The following section builds on this comparison by mapping each destination's relative strengths and drop-offs across the five journey stages. Rather than focusing on individual features, it assesses where conversion momentum is supported, and where it weakens.

## 4.3 Journey-stage strengths and drop-offs

Timor-Leste — timorleste.tl

- Awareness / Dreaming: The homepage gives a clear, high-level "why visit" proposition (beaches, reefs, mountains, culture) and immediately reinforces practical accessibility with a visible flight network list and an updated flight-route map reference ("Updated Nov 20, 2025"). This supports Dreaming by combining emotion with feasibility signals, which is important for a low-familiarity destination. A gap is that visible copy/formatting irregularities (e.g., broken word spacing in "Tim or–L este") can subtly reduce polish at first impression, which matters disproportionately in the earliest credibility moment.
- Researching / Evaluation & Planning: The itinerary system is a major planning asset, but internal contradictions undermine it as a reliable decision tool. The "Recommended Itineraries" hub labels "Atauro Island Visit" as "4 Days," while the itinerary detail page presents "2 Days," and the hub labels "Explore Dili to Jaco" as "2 Days," while the detail page presents "4 Days" with structured sections (transport, best time, day-by-day). These mismatches are not cosmetic: they directly increase traveler uncertainty during comparison and sequencing ("How long do I need?"), a core Researching-stage question.
- Booking: timorleste.tl does provide operator discovery pathways—e.g., the snorkelling page embeds a "Find a diving centre" list, and the whales/dolphins page lists "certified operators" for tours—both of which map to Booking-stage intent (who can deliver this experience). The Booking handoff is weakened by conversion friction and trust leaks: the main accommodation search page returns "You do not have permission to view this form," while multiple accommodation templates visibly expose shortcode artifacts (e.g., [/su_section]) and raw metadata/serialized location blocks. In parallel, the Terms & Conditions page contains an

unrelated embedded line (“Primos Bo’ot Accountants Timor-Leste”), a particularly harmful credibility signal because it appears in an institutional trust surface where users expect rigorous governance.

- Experience / On-ground: The site is comparatively strong on practical guidance. Safety & Health content includes specific, concrete risk and expectation-setting (crocodiles, driving conditions, water safety, mosquito-borne disease, ocean currents, and security advice including avoiding protests), which supports both pre-departure reassurance and on-ground decision-making. The Arriving page documents the electronic passenger declaration workflow (QR code generated, required on arrival) and land-border requirements, while Transport guidance provides operational detail (microlet behavior, taxi fare ranges, 4WD requirements on certain routes). The main gap at this stage is less about missing advice and more about broken link-out utility (e.g., “Find accommodation” pathways are less valuable if the directory experience is not consistently functional).
- Sharing / Post-visit: There is visible intent to stimulate post-visit advocacy, including explicit encouragement to use #HauNiaTimorLeste for sharing experiences and a set of editorial/news posts (including some with 2025 dates). At the same time, several posts display mixed date patterns (a 2025 timestamp alongside older underlying content), which can make update cadence harder for users to interpret at a glance. Compared with competitor “story libraries” that continuously publish traveler-facing narratives, Timor-Leste’s sharing layer appears less systematically surfaced as an ongoing content product.

Papua New Guinea — papuanewguinea.travel

- Awareness / Dreaming: The homepage is explicitly structured to inspire while signaling currency: it promotes “PNG Journeys” with dated story entries (including a featured item dated 22/01/2026 and multiple 2025 items), plus visible “Follow us” and Instagram entry points that reinforce social proof. It also blends identity markers (“850+ Languages”) with experience hooks (“Diving,” “Trekking,” “Birding”), and makes access feel concrete through flight-time comparisons from multiple origins. This combination strengthens the Dreaming stage by making the destination feel both extraordinary and “currently active.”
- Researching / Evaluation & Planning: The “Plan Your Trip” hub is clearly structured into planning systems (Events, Itineraries & Packages, Travel Requirements, and partner directories), reducing friction for travelers who are trying to assemble a feasible plan. “Getting Around” is unusually detailed and decision-oriented (mode-by-mode structure, named airlines, road-condition realism, and explicit safety guidance such as advising women against traveling alone on PMVs). An observed gap is uneven content polish in some areas (e.g., the FAQ page begins with placeholder-style text), which can create minor trust erosion during evaluation.
- Booking: PNG’s itinerary/package pages operate as semi-product pages: they show accommodation nights, starting prices, inclusions, and strong CTAs (“Enquire,” sometimes “Visit Website”), which helps travelers decide even without a full booking engine. Some itinerary pages also clarify what is and isn’t included (e.g., flight costs or package subsidies), reducing pricing ambiguity at the exact moment of commitment. The main limitation is that the booking pathway appears to be enquiry-based in many instances (assumption: visible CTAs lead to a form or operator handoff, but submission flow cannot be fully verified here).

- Experience / On-ground: The site provides structured pre-travel guidance as a core “Experience” enabler: Visa/Customs/Quarantine information is comprehensive and includes concrete operational concepts (passport validity, visa types, extension rules, and a defined “Green Fee” mechanism with exemptions). It also publishes practical travel tips such as banking guidance and uses destination guides that embed safety and getting-around advice inside story content, helping travelers translate generic advice into a place-based context. A smaller gap is occasional template repetition (e.g., repeated author blocks), which is more a presentation issue than a missing-content issue.
- Sharing / Post-visit: PNG Journeys functions as a living story product (with dated entries and “featured” content), and at least one story page explicitly prompts sharing (“Please help share our story”), aligning the content system to post-visit advocacy and social amplification. Instagram is also explicitly integrated from the homepage, helping convert travelers into ongoing followers. The main risk here is quality consistency—placeholder-style text in a high-level FAQ area can undercut the overall “always current” signal the story layer is trying to create.

Solomon Islands — visitsolomons.com.sb

- Awareness / Dreaming: The site’s messaging is designed around an emotional promise of remoteness and authenticity, while anchoring feasibility through familiar access framing (e.g., “just a 3 hour flight from Australia”). This works well for Dreaming because it signals both “world away” appeal and low planning intimidation for nearby markets. A gap is that some pages display older-site signals (e.g., a footer showing © 2018 on certain listings), which can make first impressions feel less contemporary even when content is updated elsewhere.
- Researching / Evaluation & Planning: “Plan Your Adventure” is a clear planning entry point with structured subpages (How to Get Here, How to Get Around, What to bring, Travel Tips, Visa Requirements) that answer standard evaluation questions without forcing users into long narrative reading. The “search machine” (filters by keyword/category/destination/things-to-do/province) appears across multiple sections and acts as a consistent wayfinding tool, supporting self-directed itinerary building. Events usability is practical rather than interactive: the Events page encourages trip timing around festivals and offers a downloadable 2025 calendar PDF, which is useful but less shareable and less “discoverable per event” than a structured event-page library.
- Booking: Many accommodation/tour pages provide direct “Book Now” and “Send Us An Enquiry” pathways and expose enough listing detail (contact info, location, and booking fields like check-in/out) to support commitment without leaving the official environment. The site also supports offer-driven conversion through “Specials” and package initiatives (e.g., Solomon Holidays packages with defined sale/travel windows), providing tangible “reasons to book now.” A smaller risk is occasional visible form/embed artifacts in the crawl output (e.g., raw form shortcode text on at least one tour page), which may signal template fragility if it is also visible to users in the live UI (assumption flagged).
- Experience / On-ground: The site provides practical on-ground expectation management in plain language—customs guidance, cash economy realities, safety common sense, dress norms, seasonality, and connectivity notes—plus packing guidance that includes culturally specific advice (e.g., appropriate town/village clothing and gift ideas). “How to Get Around” is detailed

(air/road/sea), includes local constraints (domestic baggage limits), and even includes yacht-specific protocol ("each province requires notification"), which is a strong example of Experience-stage expectation setting. The main limitation is that this content is distributed across multiple pages; it is comprehensive but requires deliberate navigation for someone looking for a single consolidated checklist.

- Sharing / Post-visit: The site demonstrates visible publishing rhythm and recency through dated feature articles (including a long-form "ultimate 7-day itinerary" published May 12, 2025) and archives showing ongoing updates through 2025. This supports the Sharing stage by giving travelers "shareable narratives" that can circulate beyond the destination website and by demonstrating that the destination is active and being written about now. The gap is not the absence of stories, but that social proof is more editorial than user-generated; the experience is narrated well, but less clearly "community amplified" through structured UGC modules.

Indonesia — indonesia.travel

- Awareness / Dreaming: Indonesia's platform is built for scale: landing pages position "Wonderful Indonesia" with wide discovery affordances (search, spotlight modules, and visible "Upcoming Event" listings with dates and categories), supporting high-volume inspiration. It also signals multilingual reach through many localized variants (e.g., en-GB, fr-FR, ko-KR, zh variants visible in page paths), which expands top-of-funnel accessibility. A visible risk is that some subdomains or variants display placeholder-like content ("UPCOMING EVENT" without further visible depth), which could create inconsistent first impressions depending on entry route.
- Researching / Evaluation & Planning: Many destination pages implement a consistent planning template—"Get There," sometimes "Get Around," "Nearby Spectacles," and embedded "Trip Ideas"—which helps users compare and sequence places as they build plans. The platform also has a structured "General Information" travel guide hub covering topics like local law, safety, visas, connectivity, embassies, and climate—useful for evaluation-stage reassurance at national scale. The most significant observed gap is governance consistency: some destination pages visibly leak raw data and template internals (coordinate arrays and even a "SELECT * FROM…" string), which undermines the professionalism of the planning layer even when information is strong.
- Booking: Booking support is present but uneven. Some flagship pages include "Travel Package" blocks with starting prices and "Book Now" CTAs plus embedded widgets (e.g., packaged experiences associated with a major landmark page), which can shorten the path from inspiration to purchase. However, other discovery interfaces appear brittle in the crawl output (e.g., "Experience" category pages showing "0 results," and a search page also displaying zero results), implying that not all pathways reliably return content depending on section. Overall, Indonesia's Booking stage appears strongest where commercial packages are curated, but weaker where discovery tools fail to populate reliably (assumption: live behavior may vary but the visible UI text indicates empty results states).
- Experience / On-ground: The country-level "General Information" hub is robust and comprehensive for Experience-stage prep, and the site publishes regulation-oriented updates (including summaries of rules for visitors in Bali referencing a 2023 circular), which helps travelers manage compliance and expectations. The platform also publishes visa-policy

explainers (including temporary policy statements and guidance to official immigration sources), though some regulation posts are older and should ideally be clearly labeled or superseded. A transparency caveat is that “Crisis Management” appears as a UI entry point but the visible content in the crawl is limited to a “Load More” state, making depth and freshness hard to confirm from what is visibly captured here.

- Sharing / Post-visit: “What They Say” influencer modules and hashtag prompts appear on many destination pages, creating a built-in social proof layer that reinforces both Awareness and Sharing. Some articles explicitly encourage following the tourism brand’s social channels, supporting a post-visit relationship loop. A structural risk is that the influencer quote blocks can look highly standardized (the same influencer excerpt appears repeatedly across different places), which may reduce perceived authenticity even while providing social proof.

**Table 4.3: Comparative Tourism Website Journey-Stage Strengths**

| Destination | Awareness | Researching | Booking | Experience | Sharing |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Timor-Leste | Strong — clear proposition + flight access cues on homepage. | Moderate — strong itinerary asset, but contradictions between hub and detail pages reduce decision confidence. | Weak — visible directory/form blockage + template/metadata leakage + trust anomaly in Terms. | Strong — unusually detailed safety/health, entry, and transport guidance. | Weak — sharing intent present (#HauNiaTimorLeste), but recency signals are unevenly surfaced. |
| Papua New Guinea | Very Strong — fresh stories (incl. 2026) + events + social integration. | Very Strong — plan-your-trip hub + detailed getting-around + interactive map. | Strong — priced itineraries with nights + Enquire/Visit Website CTAs. | Strong — robust visa/customs + travel tips and safety notes. | Strong — “Journeys” content product + “share our story” prompt + Instagram. |
| Solomon Islands | Strong — clear emotional promise + simple access framing. | Strong — clear plan-your-adventure subpages + persistent “search machine”; events via downloadable calendar. | Strong — many Book Now / Enquiry forms + specials and packages. | Strong — practical travel tips, customs, dress, connectivity, and logistics clarity. | Strong — steady 2024–2025 publishing cadence visible via dated articles and archives. |

| | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Indonesia | Very Strong — scale + multilingual reach + events surfaced on landing pages. | Strong — consistent “Get There / Nearby / Trip ideas” templates + general info hub; governance artifacts appear in some pages. | Moderate — packages exist on some pages, but discovery/experience sections can show empty states. | Strong — extensive travel guide hub + regulation updates; some sections’ depth difficult to verify from visible UI alone. | Strong — built-in social proof (“What They Say”) + hashtag/social prompts, though often templated. |

## 4.4 Strategic Implications

Timor-Leste is not structurally weak at the top of the funnel. Its homepage does key Awareness work well: it clearly states what the destination offers (marine, mountains, culture) and quickly lowers uncertainty via concrete access cues (named flight corridors and an updated flight-route map reference). In that sense, Timor-Leste competes well with Solomon Islands’ “close but world away” framing and with PNG’s “A Million Different Journeys” identity messaging (even if those are executed differently).

The momentum loss begins when travelers move into Researching and try to translate interest into a timed plan. Here, Papua New Guinea and Solomon Islands show a consistent pattern: planning hubs are treated as products, with clear subpages and structured information architecture (Plan Your Trip → Itineraries & Packages; Plan Your Adventure → How to Get Around/Here, Travel Tips).
Timor-Leste has comparable building blocks (itineraries, events, transport), but internal contradictions—especially itinerary duration mismatches between hub and detail pages—directly undermine the site’s ability to answer the “How many days do I need?” question confidently.

The sharpest comparative weakness is the Booking-stage handoff. PNG’s itinerary pages function like commercial landing pages (nights, price, inclusions, Enquire/Visit Website), and Tourism Solomons offers frequent “Book Now / Send Us An Enquiry” forms and package initiatives that give users a clear next step. Timor-Leste often routes users to operators in principle (lists of certified operators; activity-based business lists), but key conversion surfaces visibly fail or degrade: the accommodation search form is blocked for users, and many directory templates expose shortcode or serialized metadata—exactly the kind of defect that causes travelers to abandon an official site at the decision point.

Credibility signals amplify this issue. On mature platforms, travelers expect legal and “official” pages to be the most institutionally clean; Timor-Leste’s Terms & Conditions page includes an unrelated embedded phrase (“Primos Bo’ot Accountants Timor-Leste”), which creates a disproportionate trust penalty because it reads like content integrity compromise. Indonesia, despite scale advantages, shows

the same governance risk in other forms (raw database-like strings and empty results states), illustrating that “scale” and “quality control” are structurally linked problems.

Timor-Leste’s Experience-stage content is actually a competitive strength: its safety/health advice is unusually specific and pragmatic, and transport/entry pages reflect real-world conditions (4WD needs, microlet behavior, entry QR process). Strategically, this means Timor-Leste does not need to “become Indonesia” or out-publish larger destinations to improve performance; it needs to protect and connect what it already has by fixing the planning spine and eliminating trust leaks.

The prioritization implication is straightforward: the highest-return investments are not new storytelling campaigns, but journey-stitching fixes that reduce Researching friction and restore Booking confidence. Those changes allow existing strengths (marine differentiation, itinerary assets, practical guidance) to actually convert into structured intent and operator contact, rather than being undermined at the moment of decision.

## 4.5 Prioritized journey-stage fixes for timorleste.tl

1. Booking (highest priority): Repair the accommodation and listings conversion layer. Restore public access to the accommodation search experience (currently blocked), and remove visible shortcode/serialized metadata leakage on listing templates so operator and accommodation pages look authoritative at the decision point.
2. Researching: Make itineraries internally consistent and “decision-grade.” Align durations and labels between the itinerary hub and each itinerary detail page (e.g., Atauro and Jaco currently contradict), and add a standard “Trip at a glance” block (days, bases, transport, best time) at the top of every itinerary page.
3. Researching → Booking: Add consistent operator handoff modules on high-intent activity pages. Expand the “Find a diving centre” pattern beyond snorkelling and ensure each core activity page ends with a scannable “Book/Contact” module (WhatsApp/email/website) using consistent template formatting.
4. Awareness → Researching: Turn the events calendar into a planning tool. Replace (or augment) the static event table with lightweight, clickable event pages (date range, location, what to expect, how to attend, related itinerary), or at minimum provide a clean downloadable calendar artifact and ensure links are clickable rather than raw text strings.
5. Validation (cross-stage trust): Treat content integrity issues as urgent. Remove the unrelated phrase embedded in Terms & Conditions and add publishing controls/QA checks for “official” pages, since trust leaks at this layer directly depress Booking confidence.
6. Experience: Consolidate “arrival + getting around” into a single scannable checklist page. Timor-Leste already has strong entry and transport guidance; a consolidated “First 48 hours” planning page (arrival steps, SIM/cash, getting around, safety essentials) would reduce scatter and support on-ground confidence.

7. Sharing: Make advocacy visible and current. Surface a dedicated “Stories / Recent trips” feed with clear date stamps (like PNG Journeys) and connect the hashtag-sharing initiative to a visible on-site gallery or curated traveler reflections so Sharing actively reinforces Awareness.
8. Awareness: Fix visible copy/layout glitches on core entry pages. Correct broken spacing/encoding issues in key text blocks and remove draft-like editorial residue (e.g., “Make some changes” appears in municipality content), because these are small defects with outsized impact on first-time trust.

# 5. Tour Operator Representation and Product Listing Quality

International tour operators play a critical role in shaping how destinations are perceived in global markets. For emerging or lesser-known destinations such as Timor-Leste, operator websites often function as the primary planning interface. They translate abstract awareness into concrete itineraries, clarify feasibility, and signal confidence in operational delivery.

This section evaluates how Timor-Leste is currently represented within international tour-operator distribution channels. The objective is not to assess on-the-ground performance. It is to assess how clearly and confidently Timor-Leste is presented to prospective travelers.

## 5.1 Analytical Scope

A total of **22 international tour operators** actively marketing Timor-Leste were identified through systematic desk research of publicly available listings.

For each operator, the analysis reviewed:

- A dedicated Timor-Leste destination landing page (where available)
- Up to five individual Timor-Leste tour listings per operator
- Associated itinerary pages, inclusions, logistics notes, and pricing structures

The presence (or absence) of a **dedicated destination landing page** is significant. A structured country-level page signals strategic commitment and distribution confidence. It typically includes destination framing, seasonal guidance, logistical notes, and links to multiple tours. Operators without such a page often present Timor-Leste as a one-off or peripheral product, limiting discoverability and perceived commitment.

Across the operator group:

- **16 operators (73%)** publish fixed, scheduled departures with specific dates, indicating pre-committed inventory and operational confidence.
- **4 operators (18%)** operate primarily on request or bespoke models.

- **2 operators (9%)** maintain placeholder or incomplete listings, suggesting minimal active commitment.

Where multiple tours were offered by a single operator, this was treated as an indicator of depth of engagement. Operators with several Timor-Leste itineraries (varying in duration or theme) signal stronger portfolio integration than those offering a single departure per year.

Among the 18 operators specifying duration:

- The **average itinerary length is 8.4 days** (median 7.5 days).
- Most products cluster in the **6–10 day range**.
- Approximately two-thirds demonstrate broad geographic coverage (five or more named locations).
- A recognizable "standard circuit" (Dili → Atauro → Maubisse → Mount Ramelau → Baucau → Jaco/Tutuala) appears repeatedly, indicating emerging product normalization across the market.

Operators span multiple segment types:

- Global adventure brands
- Cultural and political-history specialists
- Marine and dive-focused providers
- Regional Asia-focused operators

This diversity indicates that Timor-Leste is not confined to a single niche, but is being positioned across multiple thematic segments.

## 5.2 Analytical Framework

To evaluate representation quality consistently, operator content was analyzed using a structured, rule-based content framework. Approximately **25,000 words** of publicly available marketing and itinerary text were extracted and coded.

Both destination landing pages and specific tour listings were reviewed to capture:

- High-level country positioning
- Itinerary structure and sequencing
- Logistical clarity (transport, pacing, inclusions)
- Treatment of constraints (infrastructure, permits, remoteness)
- Tone and confidence of presentation

Four analytical dimensions were applied:

**1. Presence & Commitment**

Measures the degree of visible investment in Timor-Leste as a destination.
Indicators include dedicated landing pages, number of tours, fixed departures, and completeness of listings.

**2. Accuracy & Clarity**

Assesses itinerary specificity, realistic logistical framing, currency of information, and absence of misleading claims.

**3. Narrative & Experience Framing**

Evaluates how confidently Timor-Leste is presented, how remoteness and constraints are framed (as deterrents or experiential assets), and whether listings articulate a clear "why go" proposition.

**4. Segment Alignment**

Examines whether itineraries clearly target identifiable traveler segments (e.g., adventure, cultural, marine) and whether activity mix supports coherent positioning.

Each operator was scored on a 0–2 scale per dimension (maximum 8 points). Scores are used to identify **market-wide representation patterns**, not to rank operators competitively.

The full scoring criteria, coding schema, and methodological notes are provided in **Annex C: Tour Operator Content Analysis Methodology and Scoring Framework**.

## 5.3 Interpretation Approach

This analysis captures how Timor-Leste is represented in international distribution channels — not how tours are delivered in practice.

It does not assess:

- On-the-ground service quality
- Customer satisfaction
- Accuracy of claims relative to lived experience

Instead, it evaluates how confidently and competitively Timor-Leste is positioned within the global tourism marketplace — directly supporting the strategic objectives outlined in the Terms of Reference

## 5.4 Findings: Representation by Operators Actively Selling Timor-Leste

Assessment of the 22 international tour operators actively selling Timor-Leste yields an average representation score of 5.50 out of 8 (69%), indicating generally competent market-facing representation with identifiable constraints.

- **Strong representation (6–8):** 16 operators (73%)
- **Moderate representation (4–5):** 4 operators (18%)
- **Weak representation (0–3):** 2 operators (9%)

Dimension-level averages reveal a clear imbalance in representation quality:

- **Presence & Commitment:** 1.64 / 2 (82%)
- **Segment Alignment:** 1.64 / 2 (82%)
- **Accuracy & Clarity:** 1.14 / 2 (57%)
- **Narrative & Experience Framing:** 1.09 / 2 (55%)

Taken together, these results suggest that Timor-Leste is widely presented as operationally viable, but that representation quality tends to plateau at a level of basic competence rather than achieving distinctive or aspirational positioning.

### Quantity: how much Timor-Leste is “in the market”

Of the 22 international tour operators, 73% publish fixed, scheduled departures, rather than relying exclusively on bespoke or inquiry-only models.

This includes global adventure brands such as Intrepid Travel, which offers a recurring nine-day itinerary between May and October, as well as specialist operators such as Soviet Tours, which runs seasonal departures, and Undiscovered Destinations, which offers longer-format programs of up to fourteen days.

Across the core group, listings converge on a 6–10 day tour format, with an average duration of 8.4 days. Most itineraries follow a broadly similar circuit—linking Dili, Atauro Island, the central highlands (including Mount Ramelau and Maubisse), and eastern coastal sites—supporting ease of packaging and reducing perceived logistical risk for travelers.

The quantity of listings and prevalence of fixed departures indicate that distribution presence is not the primary constraint for Timor-Leste. Instead, the binding limitation lies in how clearly and distinctively the destination is explained and positioned within these listings.

### Accuracy: clarity, specificity, and currency

Accuracy and clarity represent one of the weakest dimensions in the assessment, with significant variation across operators. At the strong end of the spectrum, operators such as Intrepid Travel, IDC Travel, and Lupine Tours provide day-by-day itineraries, clearly named locations, and transparent descriptions of transport, pacing, and inclusions. These listings enable prospective travelers to visualize

the journey and assess feasibility before inquiry, functioning as critical credibility signals in a low-familiarity destination.

At the weaker end, several distinct accuracy gaps emerge. Voyage Indonesie presents destination content without tour-level mechanics, rendering the listing informational rather than commercially actionable. In other cases, such as Mitra Travel, the use of dated PDF-based materials raises questions about content currency and responsiveness, even where product intent appears genuine.

### Quality: narrative framing and experience storytelling

Narrative and experience framing scores lowest among the four dimensions, reflecting a market-wide pattern of restrained confidence. Most operators employ moderately positive language, avoiding overtly aspirational or luxury-oriented framing. At the same time, confidence is conveyed through assertive planning language, even when logistical constraints are acknowledged.

This balance is evident in operators such as Young Pioneer Tours, which combines frequent cautionary references with a consistently confident narrative posture, and Wild Spirit Adventures, which is notable for explicitly referencing road conditions and travel times while maintaining a strong sense of operational control.

Across the sample, descriptors such as “remote,” “untouched,” and “off-the-beaten-path” are widely used and almost exclusively framed as experiential assets rather than deterrents. By contrast, explicit discussion of more challenging operational realities—such as poor road quality, long transfer times, or limited services—is relatively rare.

This produces what can be characterized as an “adventure paradox”: Timor-Leste is positioned as sufficiently adventurous to feel distinctive, but not so challenging as to trigger perceived risk or planning friction. Remoteness is emphasized, while unpredictability is softened or omitted.

**Segment alignment**

Segment alignment is generally strong but narrowly distributed. Marine and diving experiences, beach environments, and cultural or historical narratives dominate operator portfolios. Cultural and historical positioning is most coherently articulated by operators such as Lupine Tours, Soviet Tours, and Young Pioneer Tours, where independence history, village life, and heritage sites form a clear “why Timor-Leste” narrative.

By contrast, terrestrial nature experiences, wildlife observation, and cetacean-focused tourism are under-represented, appearing primarily within a small number of specialist portfolios such as Free Dive Adventures and Whale Expeditions. Food and coffee narratives are similarly marginal, despite their relevance to the destination’s agricultural identity.

## 5.5 Thematic Positioning Patterns

Thematic emphasis within tour-operator listings plays a central role in shaping how Timor-Leste is perceived by international audiences. For many prospective travelers, operator content does not merely describe what is available; it **implicitly defines what the destination is "about."** Themes that appear frequently become cognitive anchors, while those that are absent or marginal signal either limited availability, low confidence, or weak differentiation.

Analysis of approximately 2,190 thematic mentions across 21 operators reveals a destination narrative that is selectively rich but unevenly distributed, with strong consensus around certain identity pillars and notable under-representation of others. This thematic pattern helps explain why Timor-Leste is broadly understood as culturally meaningful and marine-oriented, yet less clearly positioned as a nature- or wildlife-led destination.

**Dominant narrative pillars**

Cultural and adventure themes dominate operator representation, with cultural/traditional content remaining the single most emphasized strand, now closely followed by adventure/exploration narratives Cultural/Traditional content accounts for approximately 18.3% of all thematic mentions, making it the single most emphasized narrative strand across operator portfolios. This is closely followed by Adventure/Exploration (17.7%), Marine/Diving (12.1%), Historical/Political narratives (10%), and Natural Assets (9.5%)

The consistency of these themes is striking. Adventure-related language appears in **100% of operator content**, while cultural, natural, and marine themes each appear in **approximately 95%** of portfolios. This indicates a strong degree of narrative convergence: regardless of operator type, Timor-Leste is almost always presented as culturally rich, scenically appealing, and exploratory in character.

Operators such as **Lupine Tours**, **Soviet Tours**, **Wild Spirit Adventures**, and **Young Pioneer Tours** exemplify this pattern most strongly. Within these portfolios, **50–64% of thematic content** is concentrated on culture, history, and heritage, framing Timor-Leste primarily through independence narratives, traditional village life, and post-colonial identity. This coherence suggests that cultural meaning is currently the destination's **most legible and widely trusted international story**.

**Secondary and supporting themes**

Beyond the core pillars, several themes function as secondary enhancers rather than primary drivers of perception. Portuguese heritage (8.2%), food and coffee (6.9%), hospitality and people (6.0%), and authenticity/remoteness (3.6%) appear regularly but rarely dominate. These elements tend to be woven into broader narratives rather than positioned as stand-alone reasons to visit.

A small subset of operators uses these themes more deliberately. For example, food and coffee receive elevated emphasis from **Mitra Travel**, **Tour de Trails**, and **Take Off to Timor**, hinting at an emerging but still marginal differentiation strategy. Similarly, Portuguese heritage receives focused attention primarily

from **Soviet Tours**, despite the visual and historical prominence of colonial architecture within Dili and other towns.

The limited spread of these themes suggests that they are not yet perceived by most operators as **core demand drivers**, even where underlying assets exist.

**Wildlife and nature: a visibility gap**

The most notable thematic gap concerns wildlife and terrestrial nature experiences. Wildlife and cetacean-related content accounts for only 7.6% of thematic mentions, despite Timor-Leste's location along the Ombai–Wetar Strait and its documented marine biodiversity. Explicit whale and dolphin narratives are concentrated almost entirely within a small number of specialist operators, including Whale Expeditions, Free Dive Adventures, and Twin Expeditions.

Terrestrial nature experiences—such as waterfalls, highland landscapes, hot springs, and inland biodiversity—are similarly under-represented relative to beaches and marine environments. While "nature" appears frequently as a broad category, it is often framed generically rather than through specific inland sites or wildlife encounters. This suggests that nature is acknowledged as part of the destination's appeal, but **not yet articulated as a defining or distinctive experience set**.

The absence of these themes from most operator narratives does not necessarily indicate a lack of assets. Rather, it likely reflects a combination of operational caution, limited product standardization, and uncertainty about expectation management for experiences that are less predictable or less infrastructure-supported.

**Positioning clusters and narrative strategies**

The thematic analysis reveals **three broad positioning strategies** among operators:

1. **Culture–History Led Portfolios** (approximately 19% of operators), where cultural, historical, and heritage themes account for more than half of all content. These operators present Timor-Leste as a destination of meaning and context, appealing to travelers motivated by understanding place and history.
2. **Adventure–Discovery Portfolios** (approximately 14%), emphasizing remoteness, exploration, and physical challenge. Operators such as **Mitra Travel** and **Tour de Trails** fall into this group, positioning Timor-Leste as an off-the-map experience rather than a theme-rich destination.
3. **Balanced Multi-Theme Portfolios** (approximately 48%), where three or more themes receive meaningful emphasis. Operators including **Intrepid Travel**, **Pearl Expeditions**, and **Undiscovered Destinations** combine nature, culture, history, and adventure into integrated narratives that appeal to broader traveler profiles.

Balanced portfolios are the most common and arguably the most resilient, but they also tend to dilute sharp differentiation, reinforcing the earlier finding that Timor-Leste is competently represented without being strongly singular in its positioning.

**Implications for destination perception**

Taken together, the thematic profile establishes Timor-Leste internationally as:

- **culturally significant and historically meaningful**,
- **scenic and exploratory**, and
- **marine-oriented**, particularly around Atauro Island.

At the same time, it leaves **wildlife, inland nature, food, and Portuguese heritage** as peripheral or specialist narratives rather than mainstream expectations. What operators mention frequently becomes what travelers assume is reliable and accessible; what is mentioned rarely is implicitly perceived as niche, uncertain, or unavailable.

This imbalance does not weaken Timor-Leste's credibility, but it does **narrow its perceived identity**. Thematic concentration reduces confusion, yet it also constrains differentiation in a competitive regional context. Addressing these gaps—where aligned with actual product readiness—represents one of the clearest levers for strengthening Timor-Leste's international positioning without increasing volume or inventory.

**Table 5.6: Thematic Emphasis in International Tour Operator Representation of Timor-Leste**

| Theme | Relative Visibility in Operator Content | Example Keywords | Interpretation |
|---|---|---|---|
| Natural Assets | Moderate | mountain, waterfall, landscape, scenic, pristine | Widely referenced but often in general terms; reinforces scenic appeal without strong site-level differentiation |
| Marine / Diving | High | dive, diving, snorkel, reef, underwater | Central to Timor-Leste's international appeal, particularly around Atauro Island; competitive but crowded regionally |
| Cultural / Traditional | High | culture, traditional, village, ceremony, heritage | Most coherent and consistent narrative; frames Timor-Leste as culturally meaningful and socially distinctive |
| Historical / Political | High | independence, history, resistance, occupation, conflict | Strong emphasis on independence and post-conflict history; adds depth and seriousness to destination identity |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| Portuguese Heritage | Moderate | colonial, portuguese, architecture, fort, cathedral | Present but under-leveraged despite visual and historical strength; not yet a mainstream expectation |
| Adventure / Exploration | Very High | adventure, trek, explore, expedition, discover | Appears across all operators, but often generically; signals remoteness more than specific adventure assets |
| Authenticity / Remoteness | Moderate | remote, untouched, off-the-beaten-path, authentic, undiscovered | Used to position Timor-Leste as "off-the-beaten-path," typically as an asset rather than a deterrent |
| Wildlife / Cetaceans | Low-Moderate | whale, dolphin, cetacean, wildlife, marine life | Concentrated among a small number of marine specialists; largely absent from mainstream operator narratives |
| Food / Coffee | Low-Moderate | coffee, cuisine, food, meal, culinary | Present in a handful of portfolios; not yet positioned as a core reason to visit |
| Hospitality / People | Low–Moderate | friendly, hospitable, local people, welcome, warm | Often referenced briefly to humanize the experience, but rarely foregrounded |

**Annex D has the full list of keywords for each theme.**

## 5.6 Implications for Digital Positioning and Market Readiness

Looking across how international tour operators currently present Timor-Leste, a clear picture emerges of a destination that is present, sellable, and understood in broad terms — but not yet explained with depth or distinction.

Timor-Leste appears on a meaningful number of international operator websites, often with scheduled departures, defined itineraries, and recognizable routes. This alone signals that operators believe the destination can be packaged, marketed, and delivered to travelers without excessive uncertainty. At the same time, most listings stop short of fully articulating *why* Timor-Leste is special, *who* it is best suited for beyond broad adventure or culture labels, and *what travelers should realistically expect* once on the ground.

The implications below are drawn directly from observed listing patterns, content quality, and thematic emphasis.

### 1) Timor-Leste is being sold, not merely listed

The presence of 22 international operators — many offering fixed-date departures — shows that Timor-Leste is not treated as a speculative or "contact us if interested" destination. Operators such as Intrepid Travel, Soviet Tours, and Undiscovered Destinations commit to defined itineraries, specific travel windows, and repeatable routes.

In practical terms, this means:

- operators believe travelers can be convinced to book
- tours can be run without excessive operational risk
- and Timor-Leste fits within existing product portfolios.

What is less evident is confidence beyond this baseline. Most itineraries follow similar lengths, routes, and themes, suggesting that operators are comfortable selling *known formats*, but less comfortable experimenting or going deeper.

Timor-Leste is clearly considered "sellable" by international operators, but is still presented cautiously and conservatively.

### 2) The main limitation is *how* Timor-Leste is explained, not whether it is offered

Where listings perform best is in simply *being there*: having a page, a tour name, a route, and dates. Where they perform less well is in helping travelers understand the experience in concrete terms.

Some operators — including Intrepid Travel, IDC Travel, and Lupine Tours — provide day-by-day itineraries, named locations, and clear pacing. These listings allow travelers to imagine the trip and assess whether it fits their expectations.

Others rely on broad language ("authentic," "remote," "off-the-beaten-path") without showing how those ideas translate into daily experience. In the weakest cases, listings are incomplete, outdated, or non-actionable, which can create hesitation even when interest exists.

### 3) Timor-Leste is clearly positioned for some travelers — and vague for others

Operator content consistently signals that Timor-Leste is well suited for:

- marine and coastal experiences (diving, snorkeling, beaches)
- cultural and historical exploration, particularly around independence and village life

This is reinforced by repeated emphasis across most operator portfolios and by strong thematic consistency among higher-scoring operators such as **Soviet Tours**, **Young Pioneer Tours**, and **Lupine Tours**.

By contrast, other experiences appear only sporadically:

- inland nature (waterfalls, highlands, hot springs),
- wildlife and cetaceans
- food and coffee

When these themes do appear, they are usually confined to a small number of specialist operators (e.g. whale-focused or dive-specific portfolios), rather than forming part of a widely shared destination story.

Timor-Leste is clearly legible as a marine-and-culture destination, but less clearly legible as a nature-, wildlife-, or food-led destination — regardless of whether assets exist on the ground.

### 4) Expectation-setting is uneven and poses reputational risk

Most operator listings emphasize remoteness and authenticity as positive qualities. This framing is effective in attracting travelers seeking "somewhere different," but it is often paired with limited discussion of practical realities such as:

- road conditions,
- travel times,
- service availability outside main hubs.

A small number of operators — notably **Wild Spirit Adventures** — are more explicit about these factors, while still maintaining a confident tone. Most others avoid detail, which may make trips feel easier on paper than in practice.

If travelers arrive expecting a smoother or more predictable experience than what is realistically available, dissatisfaction may follow — not because the experience is poor, but because it was insufficiently framed.

**Strategic implications for digital positioning**

Based on how operators currently present Timor-Leste, the most impactful digital positioning priorities are not about increasing exposure, but about improving understanding.

Specifically, future digital efforts should prioritize:

- **Clearer "what to expect" framing -** Supporting operators with realistic descriptions of logistics, pacing, and travel conditions, particularly beyond Dili and Atauro.

- **Stronger, more specific storytelling -** Building on credible narratives already in use (culture, history, marine life), while avoiding generic adventure language that does not differentiate Timor-Leste from regional alternatives.
- **Careful expansion of the experience story -** Where products and infrastructure allow, increasing visibility of under-represented experiences — inland nature, wildlife, seasonal whale encounters, and coffee — with appropriate expectation-setting.

Overall, current operator representation shows that Timor-Leste does not need to "prove" that it can be sold. The next step is to ensure that it is understood clearly, positioned honestly, and differentiated meaningfully in the digital spaces where travelers make decisions.

# 6. Destination Perception Mapping

**"How the destination is positioned — intentionally or not"**

This is the **synthesis engine** of Output 2.

## 6.1 Persona Snapshot Overview #1: Adventure, Eco-Exploration, Nature & Solo Traveler

**Persona name / segment:** Adventure, Eco-Exploration, Nature & Solo Traveler

**Primary motivation**

To experience remote, nature-rich, low-impact destinations that feel authentic, undiscovered, and personally meaningful — particularly marine environments, rugged landscapes, and community-based experiences.

They are motivated by:

- Novelty and rarity ("least visited," "off the beaten path")
- Marine ecosystems and biodiversity
- Independent exploration
- Cultural immersion without heavy commodification
- Personal discovery and narrative value

**Typical profile**

**Origin Markets:**

- Australia (strongest digital awareness signal)
- United States
- United Kingdom

- Secondary: Singapore, Philippines

**Travel Style:**

- Independent or semi-independent
- Flexible itineraries
- Small lodges, eco-accommodation
- Dive shops, local guides
- Comfortable with moderate infrastructure variability

**Trip Duration:**

- 7–14 days typical
- Often combining Dili + Atauro + 1–2 secondary locations
- Solo travelers stay longer than average (as seen in Booking data)

**Planning Horizon:**

- Medium (1–3 months out)
- Research-heavy before commitment
- High use of YouTube, blogs, and long-form editorial

**Why this persona matters**

This segment is already aligned with Timor-Leste's strongest validated assets:

- Diving (highest cross-platform sentiment)
- Nature and beaches
- Authenticity and community
- Positive solo traveler accommodation performance

**It represents:**

- High fit with eco-adventure investment priorities
- Fastest activation potential
- Lowest need for luxury infrastructure expansion

| Digital Journey Stage | Observable Digital Signals | What Performs Well | Where Progress Slows | Perception Outcome |
|---|---|---|---|---|

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. Awareness (Dreaming) | - Media framing TL as “least visited” or “undiscovered”<br>- Informational searches (“Where is Timor-Leste?”)<br>- Diving & marine curiosity spikes<br>- Google Trends volatility | - Strong emotional hook (remote, authentic)<br>- Diving consistently highlighted<br>- High narrative distinctiveness vs Indonesia/PNG | - Limited inspirational structuring on official site<br>- Media often frames logistical difficulty early | High curiosity. Destination perceived as rare and meaningful, but abstract. |
| 2. Researching (Evaluation & Planning) | - “Things to do in Timor-Leste”<br>- Diving research<br>- Review reading (Tripadvisor, Booking, Google)<br>- Accommodation searches | - Diving = strongest cross-platform sentiment<br>- Beaches and marine ecosystems highly rated<br>- Solo travelers show longer stays<br>- Transport sentiment stronger than expected | - Very low itinerary-search volume<br>- Weak duration-based search clusters<br>- Limited structured route guidance<br>- Internal content connections fragmented | Interest sustained, but planning requires effort. Some drop-off likely at mid-funnel. |
| 3. Booking | - Hotel searches in Dili<br>- Visa and flight research | - Accommodation ratings generally strong<br>- Dive operators validated through reviews | - Weak presence in structured tour listings | Booking likely for confident, self-directed travelers. Conversion niche but real. |
| 4. Experience (On-Ground) | - Reviews referencing diving, beaches, hospitality<br>- Transport feedback<br>- WiFi and breakfast comments | - Diving strongest sentiment category across all platforms<br>- Beaches outperform competitors in tone<br>- Warm hospitality consistent | - WiFi consistently weak signal<br>- Room consistency variability<br>- Infrastructure expectations misaligned for some | Experience exceeds expectations for target segment; friction tolerable for adventurous travelers. |
| 5. Sharing (Post-Visit Advocacy) | - Long-form travel reflections<br>- Dive content<br>- Tripadvisor & Booking reviews | - Highly positive marine storytelling<br>- “Hidden gem” narrative reinforced | - Advocacy remains niche and not systematized | Strong advocacy within adventure niche; limited spillover to |

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | - YouTube documentation | - Authenticity frequently emphasized | | mainstream markets. |

Digital signals show that Timor-Leste performs strongly at Awareness and Experience stages for this persona. The destination is perceived as authentic, marine-rich, and meaningfully “undiscovered.” Post-visit advocacy is positive and emotionally charged.

However, progression weakens during the Researching (Evaluation & Planning) stage. Interest exists — but structured trip imagination is underdeveloped. The constraint is not desirability. It is navigational clarity.

### Strategic Highlights

**1. Convert Marine Strength into Structured Trip Pathways**

Diving is the strongest validated asset across media, search behavior, and reviews. Rather than treating marine content as a standalone niche, it should act as a gateway narrative into broader exploration.

- Position diving as the entry point.
- Show how marine, beaches, culture, and nature connect sequentially.
- Introduce clear 7-day and 10-day archetypes.

This supports progression from informational search intent to structured planning behavior.

**2. Build “Trip Imagination” Content at the Researching Stage**

Search data shows low itinerary-query depth. This suggests limited structured planning signals.

- Introduce duration-based content clusters (“7 Days in Timor-Leste,” “10-Day Eco Route”).
- Visually map movement between Dili, Atauro, and secondary areas.
- Clarify travel time and sequencing.

The goal is not more volume, it is clearer scaffolding.

**3. Reframe Infrastructure Transparently, Not Defensively**

Review data consistently highlights WiFi and variability concerns. However, this persona tolerates moderate unpredictability.

- Set expectations clearly.
- Frame remoteness as part of the experience.
- Provide guidance (e.g., “best-connected properties”).

Transparency builds confidence more effectively than omission.

**4. Systematize Post-Visit Advocacy**

Experience-stage sentiment is strong and distinctive. However, amplification remains niche.

- Encourage structured storytelling from divers and solo travelers.
- Curate long-form reflections.
- Highlight repeatable narratives (marine biodiversity, warmth, authenticity).

Strong advocacy should feed the Awareness stage intentionally, not accidentally.

## 6.2 Persona Snapshot Overview #2: Marine, Diving, Sailing & Yachting Traveler

**Persona name / segment**
Marine, Diving, Sailing & Yachting Traveler

Experienced marine travelers seeking:

- High-biodiversity dive sites
- Technical or specialty diving
- Liveaboard potential
- Remote anchorage or sailing routes
- Low-traffic reef systems

This is a more technically sophisticated audience than general eco-adventure travelers.

**Primary motivation**

- Reef quality and biodiversity
- Marine rarity (pristine, under-dived sites)
- Seasonal migration events (whales, pelagics)
- Nautical exploration potential
- Technical dive credibility

They evaluate destinations comparatively and analytically.

**Typical profile**

**Origin Markets:**

- Australia (strongest dive-related search signals)
- United States
- United Kingdom
- Singapore
- European sailing community segments

**Travel Style:**

- Independent or specialist operator-led
- Comfortable in remote environments

- Often higher spend per day
- Equipment-aware and safety-conscious

**Trip Duration:**

- 7–12 days typical
- Dive-intensive itineraries
- Some extend into land-based exploration

**Planning Horizon:**

- 2–6 months
- Deep research before commitment
- Heavy use of dive forums, operator sites, reviews

**Why this persona matters**

- Marine sentiment is Timor-Leste's strongest cross-platform asset
- Aligns with national eco and marine tourism strategy
- Higher yield per visitor
- Strong word-of-mouth multiplier within niche communities

**Digital Travel Journey – Marine & Diving Traveler**

| Digital Journey Stage | Observable Digital Signals | What Performs Well | Where Progress Slows | Perception Outcome |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. Awareness (Dreaming) | - Diving-specific searches<br>- Marine biodiversity content<br>- Influencer dive footage<br>- "Best diving in [destination]" | - Strong positioning as pristine and under-dived<br>- Distinct vs Bali / mass Indonesia<br>- Marine uniqueness credible | - Low sustained visibility beyond niche coverage | Awareness is targeted and high-quality but limited in scale. |
| 2. Researching (Evaluation & Planning) | - Review reading (Tripadvisor, Google)<br>- Dive operator comparisons<br>- Accommodation searches near dive hubs | - Dive sentiment strongest across all platforms<br>- Authentic reef narrative<br>- Positive transport surprise factor | - Limited detailed marine operational content<br>- Sparse technical dive specs (depths, currents, skill level guidance) | Engagement high but reassurance incomplete. Planning sophistication not fully met. |

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 3. Booking | - Direct dive operator inquiries<br>- Hotel bookings in Dili<br>- Visa and flight research | - Small-scale operators seen as personal and warm<br>- Strong review credibility | - Limited packaged visibility internationally<br>- Lack of consolidated booking pathways<br>- No centralized marine hub content | Conversion occurs — but largely for confident niche travelers. |
| 4. Experience (On-Ground) | - Reviews praising reefs and marine life<br>- Transport and guide commentary - Infrastructure notes | - Diving = highest sentiment category<br>- Low diver density valued | - WiFi reliability<br>- Equipment logistics sometimes unclear | Experience validates marine positioning strongly. |
| 5. Sharing (Post-Visit Advocacy) | - Dive blogs<br>- Underwater video content<br>- Forum discussions<br>- High-quality imagery | - “Hidden gem” reinforcement<br>- Technical praise from experienced divers | - Advocacy not systematically amplified<br>- Remains within niche circles | Strong niche authority; limited mainstream spillover. |

Digital signals show strong interest — but engagement frequently stalls where operational clarity and reassurance are lacking.

Timor-Leste is perceived as biologically exceptional — but not yet digitally structured as a fully mature marine destination. This persona demonstrates the clearest example of high-intent digital behavior. Unlike general eco-travelers, marine and diving travelers conduct detailed, technical research before booking.

Marine strength is validated experientially, but not fully supported informationally.

### Strategic Highlights

**1. Elevate Marine Content from Inspirational to Technical**

Current narrative emphasizes beauty and remoteness. This segment requires:

- Site depth ranges
- Current intensity guidance
- Skill-level suitability
- Seasonal marine calendars
- Safety and certification clarity

Operational transparency increases confidence without reducing allure.

**2. Introduce a Centralized Marine Gateway Hub**

Currently, marine content is fragmented across operators and general pages. Opportunity:

- Create a consolidated marine landing structure
- Map dive zones and sailing routes visually
- Clarify infrastructure and logistics

This strengthens the Researching → Booking progression.

**3. Clarify Access & Nautical Infrastructure**

Sailing and yachting travelers require:

- Anchorage information
- Marina services
- Fuel and provisioning clarity
- Port procedures

Absence of this information does not repel beginners — it repels experienced marine planners.

**4. Amplify Expert Advocacy**

Marine travelers produce high-quality visual content and long-form reflections. Structured amplification could:

- Strengthen authority positioning
- Increase ranking in dive-related search clusters
- Elevate international marine credibility

## 6.3 Persona Snapshot Overview #3: Cultural, Experiential & Couple-Oriented Travelers

**Persona name / segment**
Cultural, Experiential & Couple-Oriented Travelers

Travelers motivated by:

- Cultural immersion
- History and post-independence narrative
- Community-based experiences
- Meaningful travel aligned with values
- Couple-oriented exploratory travel

This segment overlaps with editorial-driven discovery and heritage-led positioning.

**Primary motivation**

- Authenticity
- Political and historical context
- Cultural identity and resilience
- Experiential depth over checklist tourism

Media coverage consistently frames Timor-Leste through independence history, nation-building, and identity narrative

**Typical profile**

**Origin Markets:**

- Australia
- United Kingdom
- United States

These are the markets most visible in media coverage and search signals.

**Travel Style:**

- Independent
- Couple-oriented
- Editorial-influenced
- Balanced cultural + light nature interest

**Trip Duration:**

- Moderate (shorter than solo adventure travelers, based on review patterns)

**Planning Horizon:**

- Medium
- Influenced by long-form journalism
- Review validation important

**Why this persona matters**

- Aligns with national strategic positioning around culture and identity.
- High editorial visibility already exists.
- Potential to extend beyond marine-only positioning.

However, digital signals suggest limited progression into structured itinerary searches

| Digital Journey Stage | Observable Digital Signals | What Performs Well | Where Progress Slows | Perception Outcome |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. Awareness (Dreaming) | - International media coverage emphasizing independence history<br>- “Least visited” framing<br>- Informational searches | - Strong authenticity narrative<br>- Editorial credibility<br>- Cultural differentiation vs Indonesia | - Heavy emphasis on context over experience<br>- Limited inspirational structuring on official site | High intellectual interest. Destination perceived as meaningful and serious. |
| 2. Researching (Evaluation & Planning) | - “Things to do in Timor-Leste”<br>- Accommodation searches<br>- Review reading | - Positive hospitality sentiment<br>- Beaches and nature visible<br>- Strong authenticity validation in reviews | - Low itinerary-search volume<br>- Limited time-bound activity presentation<br>- Cultural experiences not structured as plannable units | Values align, but trip remains abstract. Planning clarity weak. |
| 3. Booking | - Hotel searches<br>- Visa research<br>- Limited international packaged presence | - Accommodation ratings generally strong<br>- Direct booking pathways functional | - Weak representation in international operator listings<br>- Cultural products not packaged clearly | Booking occurs selectively; scale limited. |
| 4. Experience (On-Ground) | - Reviews emphasizing warmth and authenticity<br>- Commentary on food, hospitality, transport | - Warm hospitality consistently praised<br>- Cultural authenticity reinforced | - WiFi and service consistency issues - Limited guided cultural structuring reflected in reviews | Experience generally positive and aligned with expectations. |

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 5. Sharing (Post-Visit Advocacy) | - Reflective reviews<br>- Long-form editorial-style storytelling | - Emphasis on authenticity and identity<br>- Narrative depth in reflections | - Advocacy remains within niche readership<br>- Limited scalable amplification | Strong narrative credibility; limited mainstream conversion impact. |

### Strategic Highlights

**1. Translate Cultural Identity into Concrete Experiences**

Current storytelling emphasizes history and resilience.

- Present cultural experiences as defined activities (duration, location, sequencing).
- Clarify what can be experienced in a half-day, full-day, or multi-day format.
- Connect culture to route structure.

This supports progression from informational to commercial search intent.

**2. Introduce Time-Bound Framing**

Search data shows limited itinerary-depth behavior

- Develop duration-based cultural pathways (e.g., 3-day cultural immersion in Dili).
- Clarify how cultural sites integrate into broader trip flow.

Time framing reduces abstraction.

**3. Strengthen International Product Representation**

Deliverable 2 identified limited structured international tour operator presence. For culturally motivated couples, visible packaged pathways increase reassurance and reduce perceived complexity.

**4. Preserve Editorial Credibility While Adding Practical Clarity**

Media framing is an asset The goal is not to simplify the narrative, but to:

- Pair story with logistics.
- Pair identity with itinerary.
- Pair values with visible experience flow.

## 6.4 Persona Snapshot Overview #4: Backpackers & Budget-Oriented Independent Travelers

**Persona name / segment**
Backpackers & Budget-Oriented Independent Travelers

Independent, budget-conscious travelers who:

- Seek low-cost accommodation
- Rely heavily on peer-to-peer information
- Plan flexibly and often on short notice
- Prioritize authenticity and local immersion
- Use informal digital channels for decision-making

This segment overlaps with the “least visited” narrative and independent travel framing identified in media coverage

**Primary motivation**

- Affordability
- Off-the-beaten-path destinations
- Personal exploration
- Flexibility over structure

Search and review signals show strong solo traveler patterns in accommodation data

**Typical profile**

**Origin Markets:**

- Australia
- United Kingdom
- United States

**Travel Style:**

- Independent
- Budget accommodation
- Flexible routing
- Peer-influenced planning

**Trip Duration:**

- Moderate to extended (solo travelers show longer average stays)

**Planning Horizon:**

- Shorter

- Often sequential (plan next step while traveling)
- Heavy reliance on review platforms

**Why this persona matters**

Already engaging digitally through reviews and accommodation searches.

- Contributes to occupancy and grassroots advocacy.
- However, limited evidence of high-yield growth potential.

| Digital Journey Stage | Observable Digital Signals | What Performs Well | Where Progress Slows | Perception Outcome |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. Awareness (Dreaming) | - “Least visited country” media<br>- Informational searches<br>- YouTube travel narratives | - Strong appeal of remoteness<br>- Authenticity narrative<br>- Differentiation vs Bali mass tourism | - Limited backpacker-specific visibility<br>- No structured budget travel framing | Destination perceived as adventurous and unconventional. |
| 2. Researching (Evaluation & Planning) | - Accommodation searches<br>- Review reading (Tripadvisor, Google, Booking) | - Positive hospitality sentiment<br>- Solo traveler presence evident<br>- Transport sentiment stronger than expected | - Low itinerary-search volume<br>- Limited official planning scaffolding<br>- Peer-to-peer information dominates | Planning largely bypasses official content. Independent route-building behavior. |
| 3. Booking | - OTA accommodation bookings<br>- Direct low-cost lodging searches | - Functional booking channels<br>- Generally strong accommodation ratings | - Limited budget-tour packaging<br>- No structured independent route guidance | Booking decentralized and self-directed. |
| 4. Experience (On-Ground) | - Reviews discussing rooms, WiFi, breakfast, service | - Warm hospitality • Beaches and nature appreciated<br>- Transport performance positive | - WiFi frequently cited as weakness<br>- Infrastructure variability | Experience aligns with expectations of low-development context. |

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 5. Sharing (Post-Visit Advocacy) | - Tripadvisor & Booking reviews<br>- Social media documentation | - Strong authenticity reinforcement<br>- “Hidden gem” narrative repeated | - Advocacy scale limited<br>- Influence mostly within independent travel networks | Contributes to organic awareness but not structured demand growth. |

### Strategic Highlights

Digital evidence suggests that backpackers and budget-oriented independent travelers already engage with Timor-Leste through peer-driven channels.

They rely less on official storytelling and more on reviews, informal content, and sequential decision-making. As a result, enhancements to official digital presence may have limited direct influence on this segment’s planning behavior.

This group contributes visibility and grassroots advocacy, but offers more constrained high-value growth potential.

**1. Maintain Functional Clarity Rather Than Over-Invest**

Backpackers rely heavily on peer reviews and OTAs. Priority:

- Ensure accurate, up-to-date logistical information.
- Maintain visibility in accommodation search ecosystems.
- Avoid over-prioritizing premium narrative refinement for this segment.

**2. Address Infrastructure Signals Transparently**

WiFi and service consistency concerns appear consistently in reviews. For budget travelers:

- Clear expectations reduce dissatisfaction.
- Transparency aligns with authenticity narrative.

**3. Leverage Organic Advocacy, Do Not Attempt to Over-Engineer It**

Post-visit sharing reinforces “hidden gem” perception. However:

- Amplification remains niche.
- Scaling this segment digitally does not significantly alter strategic positioning.

**4. Prioritize Higher-Yield Segments for Structured Growth**

Compared to marine and experiential couple travelers, this segment shows:

- Lower structured search intent
- Lower operator packaging visibility
- Lower revenue density

Strategic focus should remain on segments where planning depth and yield potential are stronger.

# Annex A — Tour Operator Representation Scoring Framework

This scoring framework was developed to assess how Timor-Leste is represented by international tour operators in publicly available digital channels. The objective is not to evaluate operational quality or traveler satisfaction, but to understand **market-facing representation**, including visibility, clarity, narrative framing, and alignment with identified traveler segments.

The framework supports a consistent and transparent assessment of tour operator offerings and is intended to identify **patterns and gaps** in how Timor-Leste is positioned within international tourism distribution, rather than to rank or compare individual operators competitively.

**Scope of Application**

The scoring framework is applied **only to international tour operators actively selling Timor-Leste** through published itineraries or destination pages. Operators that do not offer Timor-Leste, or that reference the destination only incidentally (for example, in blog content or as a custom request), are not scored and are instead considered qualitatively in the main analysis.

Scoring is based exclusively on **publicly accessible digital content**, including:

- Operator websites
- Published itineraries
- Destination or tour overview pages
- On-page imagery and descriptive text

No assumptions are made regarding on-the-ground service quality, pricing competitiveness, or unpublished operational arrangements.

**Scoring Scale**

Each dimension is scored on a **three-point ordinal scale**, designed to balance simplicity with analytical usefulness.

| Score | Definition |
|---|---|
| 0 | Absent, weak, or undermining representation |
| 1 | Present but limited, inconsistent, or cautious representation |
| 2 | Clear, confident, and supportive representation |

Half-points are not used. Where evidence is ambiguous, the lower score is applied and contextualized through qualitative notes.

**Scoring Dimensions and Criteria**

### 1. Presence and Commitment

**Assessment question:** *How substantively is Timor-Leste offered within the operator's portfolio?*

This dimension evaluates the visibility and seriousness of the operator's engagement with Timor-Leste.

**Indicative criteria**

- Existence of a dedicated tour or destination page
- Regularity or recurrence of departures
- Ease of discovery within the site's navigation structure

| Score | Interpretation |
|---|---|
| 0 | No dedicated presence; only ad hoc or historical references |
| 1 | Dedicated offering exists but is infrequent, seasonal, or difficult to find |
| 2 | Clear, visible offering with recurring departures and strong site presence |

### 2. Accuracy and Clarity

**Assessment question:** *Is Timor-Leste explained clearly, correctly, and with sufficient practical context?*

This dimension assesses whether essential information is communicated in a way that supports traveler understanding and confidence.

**Indicative criteria**

- Geographic and itinerary clarity
- Practical information on access, logistics, and seasonality
- Absence of outdated, misleading, or overly vague content

| Score | Interpretation |
|---|---|
| 0 | Confusing, inaccurate, or caution-heavy framing without context |

| | |
|---|---|
| 1 | Generally accurate but incomplete, vague, or hesitant |
| 2 | Clear, coherent, and confidence-building explanation |

### 3. Narrative and Experience Framing

**Assessment question:** *What story is being told about the destination and its experiences?*

This dimension focuses on how Timor-Leste is positioned emotionally and experientially, rather than on writing quality or marketing polish.

**Indicative criteria**

- Dominant tone (exploratory, aspirational, cautionary, neutral)
- Emphasis on experiences versus constraints
- Consistency and coherence of the narrative

| Score | Interpretation |
|---|---|
| 0 | Framed primarily through difficulty, risk, or deterrence |
| 1 | Neutral or factual, with limited experiential appeal |
| 2 | Coherent and engaging narrative aligned with destination strengths |

### 4. Segment Alignment

**Assessment question:** *Is the offering clearly aligned with a specific traveler segment?*

This dimension evaluates whether the operator's presentation clearly signals *who the experience is for*, using cues related to pace, activity level, comfort expectations, and thematic focus.

**Indicative criteria**

- Alignment with identified traveler segments (e.g. eco & marine, adventure, cultural)
- Explicit or implicit signaling of target audience
- Consistency between itinerary design and narrative framing

| Score | Interpretation |
|---|---|
| 0 | Target audience unclear or misaligned |

| | |
|---|---|
| 1 | Segment implied but weakly articulated |
| 2 | Clear and coherent alignment with a specific traveler segment |

**Scoring Consistency and Quality Control**

To reduce subjectivity, scoring was conducted using a two-pass approach:

1. An initial scoring pass to capture overall impressions
2. A review pass focusing on high scores to confirm that strong representation was clearly evidenced

Qualitative notes accompany each score to document the rationale and support transparency.

# Annex B - Website Performance Diagnostics & Priority Optimisation Actions

This annex provides the technical evidence underpinning the findings presented in Section 2 of the main report. It draws primarily on PageSpeed Insights diagnostics for the official tourism website (timorleste.tl), supplemented by crawl-based link integrity checks. The purpose of this annex is to document observed performance constraints, explain their likely causes, and outline a prioritized set of corrective actions.

## B.1 Performance Testing Scope and Methodology

Performance diagnostics were conducted using Google PageSpeed Insights, which combines laboratory testing with modeled mobile and desktop environments. Tests were run for both mobile and desktop profiles to reflect differences in device capability, network conditions, and rendering behavior.

PageSpeed Insights was selected because:

- it aligns with Google's Core Web Vitals framework;
- it reflects quality signals used in search ranking and user experience evaluation;
- it allows consistent benchmarking against recommended thresholds.

Screenshots and full diagnostic outputs from both mobile and desktop tests are retained as part of this annex for transparency and reference.

## B.2 Summary of Observed Performance Results

### Desktop Performance (Snapshot)

Desktop performance scores are consistently high, indicating that the site performs well under favorable conditions.

Key indicators observed:

- Overall performance score: high (mid-90s)
- First Contentful Paint (FCP): under 1 second
- Largest Contentful Paint (LCP): close to 1 second
- Total Blocking Time (TBT): negligible
- Interaction responsiveness: strong
- Layout stability: acceptable

These results confirm that the site's infrastructure, page structure, and rendering logic are fundamentally sound.

---

### Mobile Performance (Snapshot)

Mobile performance is significantly weaker than desktop, though still functional.

Key indicators observed:

- Overall performance score: moderate (high-50s range)
- First Contentful Paint (FCP): approximately 6 seconds
- Largest Contentful Paint (LCP): approximately 8–9 seconds
- Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS): elevated but not extreme
- Interaction metrics (e.g. INP): generally within acceptable ranges

The most critical constraint is delayed visual loading rather than interaction latency.

---

## B.3 Interpretation of Core Web Vitals

### Largest Contentful Paint (LCP)

LCP measures how long it takes for the most important visual element on a page to appear. On mobile, LCP exceeds recommended thresholds.

Likely contributors include:

- large hero images not sufficiently optimized for mobile delivery;
- absence of preloading for the LCP image;
- competing network requests delaying image fetch.

Impact:

- weaker first impressions;
- reduced perceived speed;
- potential competitiveness loss in mobile search results.

---

### Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS)

CLS measures visual stability during page load. While CLS values are not extreme, visible shifts occur as images and dynamic elements load.

Likely contributors include:

- missing or inconsistent image dimensions;
- late-loading elements without reserved layout space;

- font loading behavior.

Impact:

- momentary confusion during page load;
- reduced perceived polish.

---

### Interaction Metrics (INP / TBT)

Interaction metrics perform relatively well. Once content is loaded, the site responds promptly to user input.

Interpretation:

- JavaScript execution is not a primary bottleneck;
- performance issues are front-loaded (loading and rendering), not interaction-based.

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## B.4 Link Integrity Findings

A crawl of 268 pages identified only eight broken or unreachable links.

Characteristics of these links:

- primarily external URLs that have changed or expired;
- a small number of typographical or legacy domain issues;
- no broken internal navigation paths.

This confirms strong ongoing editorial maintenance and does not indicate systemic technical debt.

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## B.5 Priority Technical Fixes (Indicative)

Based on observed diagnostics, recommended actions are grouped by priority and effort.

## Priority 1: High Impact, Low to Moderate Effort

These actions directly address mobile performance constraints and are likely to yield immediate gains.

1. **Optimize and prioritize hero imagery**
    - Serve responsive image formats (e.g. WebP / AVIF)
    - Reduce image file sizes for mobile
    - Explicitly preload the LCP image
2. **Improve loading order of critical resources**
    - Ensure critical CSS is delivered early
    - Defer non-essential JavaScript
    - Reduce render-blocking resources above the fold
3. **Stabilize layout during load**
    - Define width/height or aspect ratios for images
    - Reserve space for dynamic elements
    - Review font loading behavior

---

## Priority 2: Medium Impact, Structural Refinements

These actions improve consistency and resilience rather than fixing immediate bottlenecks.

4. **Reduce unused CSS and JavaScript**
    - Audit and remove unused assets
    - Minimize bundle size for mobile

5. **Review third-party scripts**
    - Inventory analytics, embeds, and widgets
    - Remove or defer non-critical scripts
6. **Strengthen caching and compression**
    - Ensure long-lived cache headers for static assets
    - Confirm Brotli/Gzip compression is enabled

---

### Priority 3: Monitoring and Governance

These actions support long-term performance stability.

7. **Introduce ongoing performance monitoring**
    - Track Core Web Vitals via Google Search Console
    - Monitor mobile performance trends over time
8. **Establish periodic link and performance checks**
    - Annual link integrity scan
    - Quarterly performance spot checks

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## B.6 Relationship to Main Report

The findings in this annex underpin Sections 2.2–2.4 of the main report. They confirm that:

- the website is technically stable and well maintained;
- performance constraints are concentrated in mobile visual loading;

- issues are solvable through targeted optimisation rather than redesign.

By separating diagnostics into this annex, the main report remains accessible and decision-focused, while technical teams retain a clear and actionable reference for implementation.

# Annex C: Tour Operator Content Analysis Methodology and Scoring Framework

## C.1 Purpose of the Analysis

This annex details the methodology used to assess how Timor-Leste is represented by international tour operators.

The analysis supports the Terms of Reference requirement to evaluate:

- Quantity of listings
- Accuracy of information
- Quality of presentation
- Competitiveness of product positioning
  Terms-of-Reference_26900 (1)

The objective is to assess **market-facing representation**, not on-the-ground performance or customer satisfaction.

## C.2 Operator Identification and Inclusion Criteria

Identification Process

Operators were identified through:

- Search queries combining “Timor-Leste tour,” “East Timor tour,” “Timor-Leste itinerary”
- Review of major adventure and cultural tour brands
- Marine/dive specialist operator searches
- Regional Asia-focused operator review

Only operators actively publishing Timor-Leste listings at the time of review were included.

Inclusion Criteria

To be included in the analytical group, operators had to:

1. Maintain a publicly accessible Timor-Leste listing
2. Offer either:
    - A fixed-departure itinerary with dates, or
    - A clearly structured on-request program

3. Provide sufficient textual detail for evaluation

A total of **22 international operators** met these criteria.

## C.3 Data Collection Scope

For each operator, the following content was extracted:

- Timor-Leste destination landing page (if available)
- Up to five Timor-Leste-specific tour listings
- Associated itinerary breakdowns
- Inclusions/exclusions
- Logistics descriptions
- Booking instructions
- Pricing structure (if visible)

Where operators offered multiple Timor-Leste tours, variation in length, geography, or theme was captured to assess depth of engagement.

Corpus Size

Approximately **25,000 words** of publicly available marketing and itinerary text were extracted and analyzed.

Content sources:

- Primarily English-language websites
- Three operators with French-only listings were machine translated into English to ensure consistency

Visual elements (photography, video, design) were not systematically coded, as the methodology prioritizes textual traceability.

## C.4 Analytical Dimensions

The analysis was conducted using a structured, rule-based content analysis framework.

Four dimensions were evaluated.

1. Presence & Commitment

**What it captures:**
The degree of visible commercial commitment to Timor-Leste.

**Indicators coded:**

- Dedicated destination landing page (Yes/No)
- Number of Timor-Leste tours offered
- Fixed scheduled departures vs inquiry-only models
- Visibility within portfolio navigation
- Completeness of listing content

**Why it matters:**
Presence signals distribution seriousness and market confidence. Multiple tours suggest portfolio integration rather than experimental listing.

2. Accuracy & Clarity

**What it captures:**
Itinerary specificity and logistical realism.

**Indicators coded:**

- Day-by-day breakdown present
- Named locations specified
- Transport modes described
- Inclusion/exclusion clarity
- Currency of departure dates
- Absence of outdated or contradictory claims

**Why it matters:**
Timor-Leste is a low-familiarity destination. Specificity reduces uncertainty.

3. Narrative & Experience Framing

**What it captures:**
Tone, confidence, and how constraints are presented.

**Indicators coded:**

- Use of definitive vs hedging language (“will” vs “may”)
- Framing of remoteness (asset vs deterrent)
- Treatment of infrastructure limitations
- Presence of experiential storytelling
- Clarity of “why go” proposition

Constraint language was coded as:

- **Positively framed:**
  e.g., “remote,” “untouched,” “off-the-beaten-path adventure”
- **Deterrence-framed:**
  e.g., “limited infrastructure” without mitigation context

**Why it matters:**
Emerging destinations depend heavily on framing to manage perceived risk.

4. Segment Alignment

**What it captures:**
Coherence between product design and identifiable traveler segments.

**Indicators coded:**

- Dominant activity types
- Thematic emphasis (marine, culture, adventure, political history)
- Coherence of activity mix
- Implied target traveler profile

## C.5 Thematic Coding Framework

Content was coded across ten destination attribute themes:

1. Nature and landscapes
2. Marine and diving
3. Cultural and traditional life
4. Historical and political narrative
5. Portuguese heritage
6. Adventure and exploration
7. Authenticity and remoteness
8. Wildlife and cetaceans
9. Food and coffee
10. Hospitality and people

Theme frequency and distribution were analyzed to identify:

- Dominant narrative patterns
- Niche specialization
- Underrepresented themes

## C.6 Scoring Framework

Each operator was scored on a 0–2 scale per dimension.

Maximum possible score: **8 points**

Table C.1 – Scoring Criteria

| Dimension | Score 0 | Score 1 | Score 2 |
|---|---|---|---|
| Presence & Commitment | Placeholder or incomplete presence | Limited or primarily bespoke | Dedicated page + visible scheduled departures |
| Accuracy & Clarity | Missing or outdated detail | Partial specificity | Detailed day-by-day, clear logistics |
| Narrative & Framing | Generic or unclear value proposition | Competent but restrained | Clear experiential positioning and confident tone |
| Segment Alignment | Weak or incoherent targeting | Broad but diffuse | Clear alignment with identifiable segment |

Score Interpretation

| Score Range | Interpretation |
|---|---|
| 6–8 | Strong representation with credible, competitive positioning |
| 4–5 | Moderate representation with visible gaps |
| 0–3 | Weak or minimal representation limiting confidence |

Scores are used to identify **market-wide representation patterns**, not to rank individual operators competitively.

## C.7 Market Structure Signals Extracted

Beyond qualitative scoring, the following quantitative indicators were extracted:

- % of operators with fixed departures
- % offering multiple Timor-Leste itineraries
- Average itinerary length
- Geographic coverage breadth
- Presence of standard circuit patterns

These indicators provide insight into product normalization and operational confidence

## C.8 Methodological Considerations & Limitations

This analysis:

Captures:

- Publicly visible textual representation
- Market-facing confidence signals
- Positioning patterns

Does not capture:

- On-the-ground service quality
- Actual traveler satisfaction
- Visual storytelling quality
- Commercial performance data

Machine translation was applied consistently where necessary to avoid language bias.

The rule-based framework prioritizes transparency and traceability over machine learning opacity.

## C.9 Replicability

The methodology is fully replicable:

- Operators can be re-evaluated using the same 0–2 framework.
- Additional operators can be added without altering structure.
- Theme coding categories are fixed and documented.

This ensures methodological consistency for future roadmap updates.

# Annex D: Thematic Analysis Keyword Definitions

## Tour Operator Content Analysis - Keyword Lexicon

This annex documents the keyword patterns used to identify thematic content in tour operator marketing materials. The analysis employed rule-based natural language processing with case-insensitive pattern matching across destination pages and tour package descriptions.

**Methodology**: Keywords are matched using substring detection (e.g., "dive" matches "diving", "diver", "dived"). All matching is case-insensitive. The analysis counts the number of mentions per theme, not unique keywords matched.

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## 1. Natural Assets

**Definition**: References to landscape features, scenery, natural beauty, and pristine environments.

**Keywords** (n=12):
- mountain
- mountains
- landscape
- scenic
- scenery
- pristine
- natural beauty
- wilderness
- rugged
- untouched nature
- spectacular
- breathtaking

**Sample Triggers**:
- "pristine mountain landscapes"
- "rugged wilderness terrain"
- "breathtaking natural beauty"

---

## 2. Marine/Diving

**Definition**: References to diving, snorkeling, underwater activities, and marine environments.

**Keywords** (n=11):
- diving
- dive
- scuba
- snorkel
- snorkeling
- underwater
- coral
- reef
- marine life

- dive site
- liveaboard

**Sample Triggers**:
- "world-class diving"
- "pristine coral reefs"
- "snorkeling with marine life"

---

## 3. Cultural/Traditional

**Definition**: References to cultural experiences, traditional practices, local communities, and heritage.

**Keywords** (n=13):
- culture
- cultural
- traditional
- tradition
- heritage
- village
- community
- local people
- indigenous
- ceremony
- ritual
- customs
- craft

**Sample Triggers**:
- "traditional village ceremonies"
- "rich cultural heritage"
- "local community encounters"

---

## 4. Historical/Political

**Definition**: References to independence, resistance history, political development, and historical narratives.

**Keywords** (n=11):
- history
- historical
- independence
- resistance
- occupation
- struggle
- liberation
- memorial
- monument
- conflict
- political history

**Sample Triggers**:
- "independence struggle"
- "resistance history"
- "historical monuments"

---

## 5. Portuguese Heritage

**Definition**: References to colonial-era architecture, Portuguese influence, and Lusophone culture.

**Keywords** (n=9):
- portuguese
- colonial
- portuguese colonial
- architecture
- fort
- fortress
- cathedral
- church
- lusophone

**Sample Triggers**:
- "Portuguese colonial architecture"
- "historic fort"
- "colonial-era cathedral"

---

## 6. Adventure/Exploration

**Definition**: References to adventure activities, exploration, trekking, and challenging experiences.

**Keywords** (n=12):
- adventure
- explore
- exploration
- trek
- trekking
- hike
- hiking
- expedition
- journey
- discover
- kayak
- off-road

**Sample Triggers**:
- "adventure trekking"
- "explore remote regions"
- "expedition through wilderness"

---

## 7. Authenticity/Remoteness

**Definition**: References to unspoiled destinations, off-the-beaten-path appeal, and authentic experiences.

**Keywords** (n=10):
- authentic
- remote
- off the beaten path
- off-the-beaten-path
- undiscovered
- unexplored
- untouched
- hidden
- unspoiled
- frontier

**Sample Triggers**:
- "off-the-beaten-path destination"
- "authentic remote experience"
- "undiscovered frontier"

---

## 8. Wildlife/Cetaceans

**Definition**: References to whales, dolphins, marine mammals, and wildlife encounters.

**Keywords** (n=9):
- whale
- whales
- dolphin
- dolphins
- cetacean
- cetaceans
- marine mammals
- wildlife
- whale watching

**Sample Triggers**:
- "whale and dolphin encounters"
- "cetacean watching"
- "marine wildlife"

---

## 9. Food/Coffee

**Definition**: References to cuisine, culinary experiences, coffee production, and local food.

**Keywords** (n=10):
- coffee
- cuisine
- culinary
- food
- local food
- traditional food
- meal
- dining

- restaurant
- specialty coffee

**Sample Triggers**:
- "specialty coffee production"
- "traditional Timorese cuisine"
- "local culinary experiences"

---

## 10. Hospitality/People

**Definition**: References to local hospitality, friendly people, welcoming communities, and human connections.

**Keywords** (n=11):
- friendly
- hospitality
- hospitable
- welcome
- welcoming
- warm
- local people
- locals
- community
- people
- smile

**Sample Triggers**:
- "warm local hospitality"
- "friendly welcoming people"
- "hospitable communities"

---

## Summary Statistics

- **Total Keywords**: 108
- **Average per Theme**: 10.8
- **Range**: 9-13 keywords per theme
- **Matching Method**: Case-insensitive substring detection
- **Analysis Unit**: Individual mentions (not unique keywords)

---

## Technical Notes

### Matching Logic
Keywords are detected using case-insensitive substring matching. For example:
- "mountain" matches: "mountain", "mountains", "mountainous", "Mountain"
- "dive" matches: "dive", "diving", "diver", "dived", "Dive Sites"

### Counting Methodology
- Each mention of any keyword within a theme increments that theme's count by 1
- Multiple keywords from the same theme in a single sentence count as multiple mentions
- Theme percentages calculated as: (Theme mentions / Total mentions across all themes) × 100

### Content Sources Analyzed
- Destination overview pages (main Timor-Leste description)
- Individual tour package descriptions (up to 5 per operator)
- Tour titles and highlights sections
- Approximately 500-2000 words per operator depending on content depth